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consider your audience

Your audience: these are the people you are going to inform, inspire, and incite to act. Ultimately, *everything you do* when you plan, create, and deliver content is for them.

Yet, this is a dramatic shift from how we typically operate.

Take me, for instance. The most natural way for me to communicate is for myself, from my perspective, and with my preferences in mind. I live in my head, so I'm pretty familiar with what goes on in there. This means it's quite easy—I don't have to give it much thought—for me to communicate for myself.

Communicating to others is more complex. It's harder, because we have to actively work to understand them. What compels people to do the things they do? When we can identify our audience's motivations and appeal to them, we can gain their attention and drive the action we seek. In other words, it's by being thoughtful about those we are communicating to that we can get our own needs met.

In this chapter, we'll begin by prioritizing our target audience and then explore how we can better appreciate their needs. We'll also cover strategies for

getting to know an unfamiliar audience. Once we have clarity on who they are, we can tailor a great number of aspects to our audience, setting the foundation to communicate effectively.

Prioritize your target audience

Who are you communicating to? When I pose this query to clients or workshop attendees, it's not uncommon for them to hold out their hands and begin counting on their fingers. They start listing groups generally: senior leadership, the board, peers, internal stakeholders, clients, customers, the public. If I allow this to go on for a bit, they get more specific: auditors, scientists, engineers, finance, store managers, regulators.

Consider your own list of audiences, the people you communicate to regularly. As you think about the various groups, note how they're each made up of different types of people who have varying requirements.

It's almost always the case—when you are communicating in the type of instances that we are focusing on here, a meeting or presentation—that you will have a number of individuals in your audience. But even given that, we often communicate too broadly and to more people than necessary. This is dangerous because it is harder to meet multiple different needs at the same time, and multiple people will almost always have different needs.

This doesn't mean that you can't communicate to more than one person at a time. It *does* highlight, however, the importance of actively prioritizing your target audience. Then you can think about them first and foremost when you craft your approach and content.

Let's explore this idea further, starting with the simplest situation. We'll ratchet up the sophistication and complexity of scenarios from there.

Clear single-person audience

Sometimes, there is an obvious individual audience for what you're doing. Take the instance where you've been asked to tackle a project or do an analysis. Your audience is likely the person who commissioned the work. In other cases, there may be a clear decision maker. When we identify a single-person audience, we can ask ourselves: what do they care about? What motivates them? What scares them? What will incite them to act? What makes them hesitant? How do they want to be communicated to? We can design the way we do everything with that person in mind, communicating *for* that individual.

Let's make this more concrete through an example. Imagine that your organization recently conducted an employee-wide survey to measure many different aspects of the work environment. You are part of the team that has analyzed the data and are now preparing to convey the results.

One unexpected finding your analysis revealed is related to communication. Employee sentiment is generally positive, with the exception of the Engineering team. So you dig deeper, further segmenting the data. You learn that the low scores are specific to one director within Engineering. This is surprising, because he's an action-oriented and tenured superstar who is highly respected by his peers. The comments from his team indicate they don't feel he communicates frequently enough or with sufficient transparency.

We can take this feedback into account when we set our communication plan. We need to relay that something isn't going well. But before simply jumping in with that, let's think about *him*—the director. There are a number of different ways we could position this finding. It might be framed as an opportunity to tackle or a blindspot to address. Perhaps he'd be best motivated by the positive impact he could have on his team's productivity by making changes to how he communicates. Or maybe the risk of losing credibility with his peer group would get his attention.

None of the ways I've outlined to potentially position the message are inherently right or wrong. They are different, and they are personal. Taking that a step further, while I wouldn't call them right or wrong, there are definitely better or worse approaches based on *who you are communicating to* in a given situation.

Use competition to drive action

I'll share another relevant lesson from my husband's experience. He was working for an organization leading HR and wanted to make changes to the paternity leave program. He recognized that he might face resistance; this wasn't necessarily high on the CEO's priority list. He also knew that this particular leader cared tremendously about offering benefits and a work environment that were at least as good as, if not better than, other organizations in the industry. Rather than lead with the idea to increase paternity leave, the HR team tried a different technique to get the CEO's support. They started by presenting the paternity leave offered by peer companies. Then they showed their own shorter leave program. They asked the CEO what he wanted to do: keep the status quo or make adjustments. With this positioning, they were able to motivate him to suggest the changes. They accomplished this by being thoughtful about how to best influence the individual.

When you have a clear single-person audience, you can address them directly. There are many aspects of how you communicate that you can tailor, which we'll discuss later in this chapter. Before we get there, let's examine the more common scenario: a mixed group.

Narrowing within a mixed audience

Mixed audiences—those consisting of people from different teams across an organization, having varying levels of seniority, or representing a multitude of

companies—are challenging. The individuals who comprise them have distinct preferences and may not be aligned on the things they care about or upon which they are willing to act. It's hard to meet multiple priorities simultaneously or to encourage a group to act in a certain way when individuals are motivated by different factors. Yet, mixed audiences are a reality, and we can be smart about how we communicate to them.

When you find yourself facing a mixed group, the first thing to ask yourself is whether you can narrow it. Could you prioritize a person or smaller subset with shared interests and focus first and foremost on them?

The answer is often yes.

Let's explore this further. Imagine you work for a company that is getting ready to launch a new product. You're trying to determine how to price the product in the marketplace. The team you manage has undertaken an analysis of competitor pricing as one input into the decision-making process, and you are the one who will be communicating it.

Let's start by casting a broad net and list some prospective audiences. Who will care how we price our product? First, there are the internal stakeholders. The board will be interested in pricing. Senior management will care. Within that group, there are various people who will be involved (for different reasons): the CEO, the CFO, the Head of Product, and the Head of Sales, to name a few. Finance will want to be apprised because they'll have to factor price into their revenue models. The Sales team will be interested since they'll be the ones trying to sell the product in the marketplace. What about external stakeholders? Retailers will care how we're priced when determining whether to carry our product. Competitors will pay attention as a potential input into their own strategies. Consumers will want to know as they weigh their purchase decisions. The whole world may eventually care!

I'm being facetious to emphasize that there are a number of different potential audiences. How can we communicate successfully with so many disparate

groups in mind? We can't! They care about different things. There are distinct actions we'd want each to take. We cannot communicate to all of them simultaneously. Or perhaps I should rephrase to say that, if we were to do so, we would not be successful.

We should narrow our audience for the purpose of our communication. There is a process, and more specifically, two steps we can take: narrow to now, and then identify the decision maker.

When it comes to **narrowing to now**, I mean contemplating who has to be communicated to at the current point in time. Eventually, all of the groups we listed could be interested in how we price our product, but they aren't necessarily each concerned at this moment. Let's think about our audience in the near term. The product isn't even in the marketplace, so we can strike external stakeholders from the list. We haven't yet priced it; that eliminates Finance and Sales from caring. That leaves the board and the leadership team. Narrowing to now helped us focus on a smaller group.

Next, let's **identify the decision maker** within our already reduced audience. Our goal is to price the product. The board won't be making that decision, so let's cross them off our list. That leaves us with the leadership team. Each individual may have a stake in the product price and provide input. However, they don't all have decision-making responsibility. The ultimate decision makers will be the Head of Product and the CEO. We've just successfully narrowed our audience from the whole world (or if not that, at least a lot of people) to two specific individuals. Success!

Adapting for the virtual setting

Virtual meetings are now the norm in many organizations. With this format comes some new and unique advantages—and challenges. What once might have been a small in-office meeting can expand greatly in number of attendees due to the ease with which virtual allows us to include more people. When the invite list grows, consider whether scaling back is possible or preferable. Just because you *can* invite everyone doesn't mean you *should*. When you don't have control over this aspect, take care to prioritize your target audience and apply select strategies outlined in the forthcoming section for communicating successfully to a mixed group.

Stepping back, not a great deal changes for the virtual environment when it comes to how we plan for our communication. There are distinct ways to optimize the materials we present for a virtual setting, which we'll discuss in the *create* chapters. Equipment and delivery differences also exist, which we'll explore in Chapters 9, 10, and 12.

This intentional process of narrowing our audience makes our jobs as communicators easier by reducing the variety of personalities and individual concerns we need to address. When getting this targeted is possible, do it. In other instances, you may face a true mixed group where you must communicate to multiple individuals simultaneously. Let's examine that now.

Facing a mixed audience

The leadership team, a steering committee, employees, customers, conference attendees: these are the kinds of groups I have in mind when someone says they have to communicate to a diverse audience. This is a tough scenario, for the reasons I've outlined. It's hard to meet varying demands equally and

simultaneously. Still, there are absolutely things you can do to set yourself up for success. Let's discuss a few strategies.

Recognize—and call out—differences. One way is to start by acknowledging up front that people are coming from different viewpoints and have disparate needs. In a live meeting or presentation, articulate this challenge of mixed interests. Have a thoughtful plan on how you'll address those diverse preferences. For example, if I'm presenting a project proposal to a steering committee made up of individuals from various parts of the company, it could make sense to stick with the big picture and not get into the details. But if I know that some people are going to want more than that, I can explicitly call it out: "I'm going to stay high level today. Tom, I know you're going to want me to elaborate; I'm happy to sit down with you afterwards to walk through it." Even better—meet with Tom ahead of time to deliver his desired level of granularity so you are able to remain focused on the big picture when everyone is together.

On stage in a conference setting, you might set expectations by first explaining: "I appreciate that there are attendees with varying levels of knowledge on the topic about which I'll be speaking. I'm going to take a short amount of time up front to cover the basics, and then we'll quickly get more nuanced from there." This tells everyone in advance that their needs have been recognized and will be accounted for in some way before you're done.

Identify areas of overlap. Flipping the prior strategy around, rather than reflecting on how people or segments are different, look for similarities. Is there a common goal or pain point that will unite a group or anchor what you're going to discuss? The Big Idea worksheet is sometimes a useful tool at this juncture, which we will dive into deeply in Chapter 2. The most pertinent part to consider is *what is at stake* for your audience. In the case of a mixed group, thinking through this for each member or similar segment can be useful. Identify areas of overlap that may help you frame your approach. Recognize the consistent theme and use that to pique people's attention, get them on the same page, and motivate them to act.

Creating personas for different categories of people

When facing a large mixed audience, it is sometimes useful to create personas to segment the group and the differing perspectives you could face when presenting. These can be based on their desires or motivations and often means generalizing. I might craft Persona A, an individual with a certain type of role or personality (articulate it); who has a similar set of biases (list them); who typically cares about A, B, and C; and who is most likely to question X, Y, and Z. If you have 100 different people in your audience, it will be impossible to envisage these dimensions for each person. But if you group them into a handful of similar subgroups, it stops you from throwing your hands up in the air and simply saying, *I can't address them all*. By segmenting similar individuals in this way, you think about a number of different viewpoints and preferences, which better equips you to address them. Once you have a comprehensive mapping of the main personas, step back and strategize how to best inform them in light of their personalities and requirements.

Show something that relates to everyone. Building on the idea of looking for commonalities, one way to create areas of overlap is to show everyone something that is relevant to each person that can be compared across the broader group. Let's take the employee survey scenario that I mentioned earlier and put a twist on it. Suppose we must disseminate the results to the entire leadership team. I might include a table or graph that shows an interesting piece of the survey—for instance, the aggregate favorable score across themes broken down by the areas each individual on the leadership team oversees. This provides everyone with similar context: they see how their own function performed relative to the others and the overall company. There may also be consistent high points or low points that can be used to introduce the next level of detail or drive good discussion.

If you've ever been in a conference setting where the presenter shows a demographic breakdown of the audience or introduces real-time polling and shares the results, this is an attempt to do the same thing. They are showing something that relates to everyone and getting people involved so they are more willing to pay attention to what follows.

Verbalize to gain attention. When addressing a mixed group, you don't necessarily need everyone's attention equally all the time. Given this, when you want to make sure you have a specific person's or segment's focus (particularly where you may have lost attention by covering other content less relevant to this subset), call that out. For example, assume you are communicating to a steering committee made up of various individuals. I could say something like, "Jane, you're going to want to listen to this part because it involves your group." Or, taking the instance of a conference keynote address, I might announce, "Managers in the room, this upcoming strategy is one you'll want to bring to your teams." In this way, use vocal cues to ensure you have the right people's attention when you seek it.

Irrespective of which of these strategies you employ or combine, when you face a mixed group, ask yourself: what does success look like? Acknowledge what you can reasonably accomplish in the mixed group setting and which pieces should be broken out and shared separately in a more targeted way.

Whether dealing with a single person, communicating to a small group, or presenting to a large mixed audience, you'll have to take steps to get into their heads and understand them. Let's address that next.

Understand and assess your audience

You may know your audience. Perhaps you've communicated to them before. But have you ever paused and spent time critically assessing their priorities, preferences, and requirements? When the stakes are high, this is a task worth undertaking.

While there will be queries specific to your situation that are important to identify, this starter list of questions will help you better understand the people to whom you are speaking:

- What do they care about? What drives them?
- What scares them or keeps them up at night?
- What motivates them? What causes them to want to act?
- What prevents them from acting or makes them hesitate?
- What do they like? What makes them happy?
- What annoys or irritates them?
- To whom do they listen? What influences them?
- What is their opinion of you? Are you credible in their eyes?
- Why will they support you? (In a mixed group, *who* is likely to support you?)
- Why might they resist you? (In a mixed group, *who* will resist? Why?)
- What biases do they have?
- What constraints bind them?
- How do they measure success?

Draw and brainstorm to better understand your audience

Grab a blank piece of paper and a writing utensil for this quick exercise. Orient the paper in landscape fashion (where width is greater than height). Picture a person in your audience and then draw them in the middle of the paper, leaving blank space on either side. Your depiction will remind you that you are doing this all for someone else.

It's okay if you aren't an artist. The drawing can be a simple face or stick figure (though if you prefer to get more creative, go for it). Add a title for the person underneath your sketch. If it's a specific person, use their name or genericize with something like "supportive manager" or "hesitant client."

On the left-hand side, write words or phrases describing why the person is likely to support you. What's going to be easy? Where will they agree with you? On the right-hand side, list reasons the person might resist you. Where do they have biases or skepticism? What points will you make with which they may have contention? Try to get inside this person's head, and acknowledge or make assumptions about what drives them to feel the way you've outlined.

When you're done, read through it all and reflect: given the ways you expect support or are likely to meet resistance, how can you best set yourself up for success?

What if I don't know what my audience cares about?

Remember, the reason we are doing all of this is so we can be thoughtful about how we communicate to our audience, taking their needs into account. But what do we do if we *don't know* our audience? How do we tailor our

approach to meet their preferences? Here are some tactics for getting to know an unfamiliar audience.

Talk to them. When you have direct access in advance to your audience and it makes sense to speak with them, do so. This isn't always feasible, but when it is, start here. Ask questions. Work to understand what we've discussed: what they care about, what motivates them, and what scares them. If you can't connect with your audience ahead of time, look for opportunities to understand their preferences directly before or during your presentation. Use the moments before you start to chat with people and ask questions to gain insight. Alternatively, at the beginning of your presentation, prompt discussion to uncover attendee expectations. Use that knowledge to resonate with them through your choice of words and how you navigate your materials.

Talk to someone who knows them. When you can't speak to your audience directly, consider whether there is someone who knows them with whom you could have a conversation. This could be someone who works with them or has previously communicated with them successfully—or unsuccessfully. Get insights from their work with your audience.

Talk to people who are similar to your audience. Determine what aspect of your stakeholders are least familiar to you. Are they in a role or job function that you haven't communicated to before or at a different skill level? Do they work in an industry with which you are less familiar? Find someone you can speak to who can lend a similar perspective or other helpful context.

Collect data. In some cases—for example, if you are communicating to potential consumers of your company's products or services—you may undertake market research to better understand your target audience. Other ways of collecting data include piloting or beta testing to learn how people are using your product and get feedback about their motivation. For a conference presentation, ask for information on attendees. Many conference organizers will share aggregated data about industries, companies, and roles so you can get a sense of who they are.

Read about them. If you'll be presenting to a prominent person, company, or organization, look for information online. Browse their website, look at current job postings, scan social media, and read related news. Even in the instance where it's an individual or group you're communicating to, this will give insight into the organizational culture, which can help your framing.

If you don't do any of these things—due to time constraints or other reasons—you are left to make assumptions about what matters to your audience and how best to convey information to them. When you do, think critically about how your audience is different from you. Often when we communicate, our default is to assume that everyone has the same priorities and preferences as we do. Be clear on where they are likely to deviate. This will help you to express your needs with *their* goals in mind.

Identify & pressure test your assumptions

Any time you make suppositions—whether about your audience or elsewhere as part of your project, analysis, or communication—discuss them with colleagues. Ask your peers to help you identify and pressure test any assumptions you're making by asking critical questions. If you've presumed something incorrectly, does that change things? How? In some cases, a wrong assumption won't have material impact, whereas in other situations it could change everything or call your credibility into question. Be aware of when you are making assumptions and make them as bulletproof as possible.

Working to better understand your audience and getting to know unfamiliar audiences takes time. But when the stakes are high, it's worth the effort because it means you can customize the way you communicate with their preferences in mind. Let's shift our attention to address that challenge.

Tailor for your audience

Your general approach, the materials you create, and the environment in which you meet are important aspects of the communication you can tailor specifically for your audience. Below, I've listed some questions that may help you identify specifics for each. They are primarily framed from the standpoint of having a single person or small group audience (rather than a conference session with many attendees, though you can consider variations for that scenario, too). This is not a comprehensive list but rather some ideas to get you started.

General approach

- **How do others want to be communicated to?** Will they favor an in-person meeting, a video conference, or phone call or email?
- **What's a good amount of time to plan for?** Should you keep things quick to respect their busy schedule, or do you expect they'll be generous with their time?
- **How can you best frame the general conversation?** Do they want you to build to your main point, taking them first through the relevant context, or lead by directly answering the question, "So what?"

Materials

- **How formal do you need to be?** Will your audience demand a polished slide deck or might a casual conversation better suit?
- **How do they want to receive information?** Would they prefer you send a pre-read ahead of time and meet to address questions or that you cover everything during the designated time?
- **How can you best share information?** Do they want to see slides presented on a screen or have a printed handout to flip through and use to record their notes?

- **What level of granularity do they care about?** Is it better to stick to the big picture, or will they want to go through the full details?
- **Will you incorporate data and graphs?** Does your audience value or expect data? Do they embrace or reject graphs? Should you stick to the basics, or is complex okay?

Environment

- **Where do you meet?** Do they want you to come to their office, meet in a conference room, or walk and talk? If it's a video conference, what is their preferred technology?
- **What time of day is best?** Are they energized in the morning, impatient before lunch, or typically frustrated after a specific regular meeting?
- **Should you involve others?** Will you be best off communicating on your own? Would it make sense to involve members of your team, a supporter from elsewhere in the organization, or an influencer whose involvement could help ensure success?

When you step back and think about it, you can customize numerous facets of how you plan material for your audience. You won't always be able to optimize for every element. But the more you *can* do, the better. As we discussed at the onset of this chapter, when you meet your audience's needs, you put yourself in a great position to get your own met as well.

Next, let's take a look at how to apply the ideas we've just framed.

Consider your audience: TRIX case study

I'll introduce a scenario that we will revisit throughout this book. This will allow you to see the progression through the various planning stages, the way they come together into presentation materials, and how you can prepare and deliver a stellar presentation using a real-world model. This situation is based on actual events, with details changed to preserve confidentiality.

Imagine that I work at a market research firm that gathers and analyzes information about consumer preferences. I've just led a pilot project with a new client, a prominent food manufacturing company called Nosh. If this trial run goes well, Nosh will enter into an ongoing partnership with my firm to conduct market research across all of their product lines. In other words, the stakes are high.

Nosh is interested in reworking the blend for their popular trail mix snack product, TRIX, to reduce the cost of production. Together with my research team, I've analyzed the competitive landscape and performed an in-depth study across a variety of dimensions of the current TRIX trail mix. This included the design, execution, and data analysis of a series of tests to understand consumer preference related to alternative recipes and packaging. With the help of my team, I am planning the communication—a slide deck—that I will present to Nosh outlining our findings and recommendations.

My overarching goal is to drive a discussion among the group I'll be presenting to and have them make a decision on what, if any, changes to make to the trail mix ingredients and packaging. Further, I'd like them to be sufficiently impressed with my team's work so that they recommend shifting Nosh's business in this area to our firm.

Let's start by prioritizing the target audience. Many people will be impacted by the outcome of whether to change the trail mix: individuals across numerous parts of Nosh and even outside of it if we include suppliers and customers. We don't, however, need to form our communication with all of

these groups in mind. Many of them will be addressed through additional communications downstream.

If I narrow to now—the current point in time—and the decision makers, I should target the team that has been assembled from Nosh to interface with me on this project. It is a mixed group, each with unique personalities, perspectives, and interests. Let's examine the individuals who comprise it.

Vanessa is Head of Product for the product line that includes TRIX trail mix, our focus for the pilot project. She is the individual who commissioned the study with my firm and will be an advocate for ongoing work, assuming she's dazzled by what I demonstrate. On the one hand, she seems hesitant to change what time has proven is a strong product. However, she understands that the rising cost of a main ingredient is making the current mix untenable. She is highly concerned about the negative impact that modifying the product mix could have on consumer sentiment and the overall success of the TRIX brand.

Matt is Vanessa's chief of staff. He's been one of my primary points of contact throughout the project, helping to provide direction and in some cases insight into Vanessa's preferences and how to best work with her. Matt is relatively new to Nosh—he started only a few weeks prior to the beginning of this project—but he came up to speed quickly and has the benefit of having worked with Vanessa in a prior role as well as her trust. By keeping him apprised and on board with the direction I'm taking, he may be able to help influence Vanessa in useful ways.

Jack is the divisional CFO. He has a strong personality and looks closely at the numbers and cost—when he's present. Jack has a busy schedule and often misses or arrives late to project meetings. When he's unable to attend, he sends Shannon from his team to represent Finance. Shannon doesn't say much, but when Jack attends, he is extremely detail oriented and expects immediate and clear answers to his questions. Given all of this, it could make sense to meet with Jack and Shannon separately ahead of the final presentation to share full detail, get Jack's perspective, and fully answer any questions.

Jack's perception of the overall project will influence whether Nosh pursues ongoing work with my firm, so it is critical that it be a positive one.

Riley is the VP of Marketing for the TRIX brand. She's likely to be resistant to changes that will impact the marketing assets her team has already created. This includes packaging changes, which would render some marketing materials obsolete, resulting in more work for them to create new advertising collateral.

Charlie is the Customer Satisfaction Manager for the TRIX product line. He is concerned about changing what historically has been regarded as a magical mix of ingredients due to strong favorability in the market. Charlie seems to be the most risk-averse out of the group. I will need to get him comfortable with our procedures and be thoughtful about how I frame suggested changes, particularly if there's any uncertainty around consumer sentiment.

Abbey and Simon are two sensory scientists from Nosh's R&D team. It is the limited bandwidth of their team—who would normally do this type of work but is concentrating primarily on new products rather than changes to existing ones—that led Vanessa to contract my firm in the first place. Though I feared there might be some territorial issues, that hasn't materialized. Instead, Abbey and Simon have each contributed some helpful guidance that indicates support of our work. They are also meant to provide a review of our methodology to ensure consistency with the R&D team's internal processes, which my close communication throughout the project has hopefully helped safeguard.

Clearly, the people in this group have varying desires and objectives. Though they have disparate individual concerns, one care that unites them is the success of TRIX trail mix. Balancing customer sentiment and cost to manufacture will be of high interest to the group. I will use this common ground to set the stage, walk through options, and frame a hopefully fruitful discussion that leads to clear decisions.

I know our team has done amazing work here—all that's left is to convince the client group at Nosh. I've built some understanding of the various personalities

I'll be presenting to from the meetings we've had with them so far. Some of the clear allies within that group can provide insights to further inform how to best tailor my approach and materials. My final presentation to the full client group has been scheduled for three weeks from today.

We've done it: we've considered our audience. Let's turn attention to our message.



chapter 2

craft your message

You've identified your target audience and acknowledged their needs. Next comes what might seem like an obvious question: *what do you want to communicate?*

Too often, we don't pause to think about this. We finish our project or decide on a presentation topic and begin indiscriminately generating content, creating slides or directing others to do so on our behalf. But if we can't succinctly articulate our point, how do we pull together content that will get that message across? That's a tough feat.

Counter that with the scenario where you are able to simply state your key message in a sentence. This puts you in a much stronger position to intentionally plan your materials.

What should my audience do?

When you are getting ready to communicate, identify what you want others to do—a specific action they should follow. The action itself can take many different forms. It could be a discussion, options to weigh, an idea to respond to, or a decision to make. This is an area in which presentations often fall short. We spend a great deal of time putting together content and taking our audience through masses of information without ever thinking about what we want them to actually *do*. What specific activity will your hard work inform? If you can't clearly articulate the action, you should consider whether you need to communicate in the first place.

We'll touch upon the 3-minute story briefly and cover the Big Idea in depth as tools to empower you as you craft your communication. A clear message helps everything else in the process run smoother, from planning and preparing content to talking to others and getting the attention and action that you seek.

Let's discuss what these concepts are and how to use them, then I'll illustrate through example.

Form your 3-minute story

The 3-minute story is precisely what it sounds like. If you had only a few minutes to tell your audience what they need to know, what would you say? In this boiled-down version, it's essential to recognize the critical components that must be included. It's equally useful to have a good understanding of which details you can omit. The 3-minute story is useful in the event that you encounter a stakeholder (in the elevator or as the first other person on a video conference, for instance) and want to give a quick update or get some input. It's also helpful in the instance where your allotted time on the meeting agenda is reduced.

If you've already formulated a succinct version, it means you know your stuff. You understand your story. You can make it fit into the designated period. It also reduces reliance on your slides, which is a useful feat.

The 3-minute story has an important word in it—*story*. We'll delve into story in Chapter 4. At this point, let's use a simple definition: something that has a plot, a twist, and an ending. In your 3-minute story, the plot is the context to set for your audience so they are ready to take in what you're going to communicate. The twist encapsulates the interesting or unexpected part, or the new information that is critical to understand. The ending is the call to action: what you want your audience to do in light of the information you've shared. To recap, here's the 1-2-3 of the 3-minute story:

1. **Plot:** the context for your audience
2. **Twist:** the new information your audience needs to know
3. **Ending:** the action you want your audience to take

It is helpful to write out the 3-minute story that includes these components. Then read through it aloud and refine (we'll revisit this strategy of practicing out loud in greater detail in the context of refining our presentation in Chapter 9). We'll look at an example later in this chapter.

Once you've formulated your 3-minute story, it becomes an anchor from which you can either expand or condense—and there is value in realizing each of these additional forms. You may expound upon it when discussing your project with a colleague for feedback, in a preemptive conversation with a detail-oriented stakeholder, or when planning your approach to ultimately communicate your work. We'll explore the latter in Chapters 3 and 4 when we brainstorm potential content, organize it in a storyboard, and then arrange it into a robust narrative.

But before we expand on our story, let's practice condensing it. I introduce the 3-minute story concept first because it is difficult to go from the overall scenario down to a single sentence—which is where we're heading next.

Compose the Big Idea

Remember the idea I began with in this chapter? We often go straight to our tools and start building content without necessarily having a clear goal in mind. The Big Idea is that end goal—the key message you want to get across. Think of it as your guiding North Star, helping to direct you through the process of generating supporting content. Once you’ve formulated it, you have a built-in litmus test for the content that you contemplate including: will it help me get my Big Idea across?

I adapted the Big Idea—which I first read about in Nancy Duarte’s *Resonate* (Wiley, 2010)—for use in workshops and have taught and practiced forming and using it with thousands of people over the years. It is one of the most important concepts that we teach.

The Big Idea should:

1. Articulate your point of view,
2. Convey what’s at stake, and
3. Be a complete sentence.

Let’s review each of these elements.

Articulate your point of view

The first component encourages you to be specific and frame what you think about the matter. One pitfall I sometimes see people stumble into as a result of the single-sentence restriction is that they are too general with the Big Idea. “Let’s improve processes to make more money.” While no one would argue with that statement, it also isn’t meaningful since we’ve kept things at such a high level that it doesn’t convey anything tangible or compelling. For success, you actually want to go the other direction—get specific. “By fixing this particular pain point in our sales process, we estimate we can keep an additional 10% of potential customers from falling out of the process, leading to increased revenue of \$300K.”

Depending on the scenario and the audience, we might make that even more explicit by rephrasing to recommend a definitive action: “Approve the spend required to fix this pain point in our sales process, allowing us to save potential customers who would have otherwise fallen out of the sales process and leading to increased revenue.”

Convey what is at stake

In conveying what’s at stake, this is not what is at stake *for you*, but rather what is at stake *for your audience*. This often means a paradigm shift because you are much more used to explaining why someone should care from your perspective than from theirs. Framing your Big Idea for your audience means focusing on what will be most compelling for them. It’s the value proposition, the answer to the question of why they should listen to you. It brings the ideas that we discussed in Chapter 1 clearly through into our messaging.

You can articulate what is at stake with positive or negative framing. **Positive framing** means focusing on what the audience has to gain or the benefits if they act in the way you recommend. **Negative framing** is the opposite. What do they stand to lose or what are the risks associated with *not* acting accordingly? As a thought exercise to help figure out what is at stake, I’ll often prompt people to start by imagining the absolute worst-case scenario: your audience doesn’t follow what you recommend, which leads to X (that’s not good), which leads to Y (that’s even worse), which leads to Z (absolute disaster). Once you’ve hit rock bottom, figure out how much to back off from there to appropriately match the given circumstance. Do the same activity in the positive direction. Then decide which will better suit your audience and the situation.

Make it a complete sentence

This is not a bulleted list or a half-thought; the Big Idea is a complete sentence. Perhaps more challenging, though, is that it be a *single* sentence. While it sounds simple to write or say a sentence, when it’s work that you’re close to, this is often difficult. But it is also incredibly worthwhile.

The single-sentence constraint, while arbitrary, is an important one. First, when you're only allowed a sentence, it forces you to let go of the minutiae. You have to ruthlessly prioritize what you include because there is limited space. This effort will help you home in on your key message. Given the length limitation, every word is important. This means that when you write and rewrite and incorporate feedback (we'll talk more about all of this soon), you may find yourself repeatedly replacing words or changing the phrasing. While this wordsmithing doesn't always feel productive as you're working through it, there is important clarity of thought that arises along the way.

The beauty of constraints

Time constraints. Tool constraints. Space constraints. People often view these as negative forces imposed upon them. I encourage you to reframe. Constraints breed creativity. Self-imposed constraints—like the single-sentence restriction for the Big Idea or the beneficial space limitations of small sticky notes that we will soon discuss—can help you problem solve in new ways. To hear more on this idea, check out Episode 5 of the *storytelling with data* podcast, entitled “the beauty of constraints” (storytellingwithdata.com/podcast).

One tool that is helpful for crafting your single-sentence message is the Big Idea worksheet.

The Big Idea worksheet

When I first started teaching the Big Idea in workshops, I'd introduce it, give a couple examples, and then ask attendees to draft the Big Idea for a specific communication need. This worked reasonably well, but I found that participants sometimes struggled. So I developed a better method: the Big Idea worksheet. The worksheet breaks the Big Idea into its component pieces and

poses targeted questions about each. Once you've answered the individual questions, you simply have to fit them together in a way that makes sense as you would the pieces of a puzzle.

Figure 2.1 shows the Big Idea worksheet.

the BIG IDEA worksheet

Identify a project you are working on where you need to communicate something to someone. Reflect upon and fill out the following.

PROJECT: _____

WHO IS YOUR AUDIENCE?

(1) List the primary groups or individuals to whom you'll be communicating.

(2) If you had to narrow that to a *single person*, who would that be?

(3) What does your audience care about?

(4) What action does your audience need to take?

WHAT IS AT STAKE?

What are the *benefits* if your audience acts in the way that you want them to?

What are the *risks* if they do not?

FORM YOUR BIG IDEA

It should:

(1) articulate your point of view,

(2) convey what is at stake, and

(3) be a complete (and single!) sentence.

FIGURE 2.1 The Big Idea worksheet

Using the Big Idea worksheet is simple. Identify a project you are working on where you need to communicate something to an audience. Then take about ten minutes to complete the worksheet. This culminates in you drafting a Big Idea. Building up to it in this piecewise manner helps you break free of the natural inclination to communicate first and foremost for yourself by forcing you to think critically about your audience. As discussed previously, this means centering your message around not why *you* think they must act in a certain way, but rather why *they* should want to.

We'll look at a specific example using the Big Idea worksheet momentarily. First, let's review some frequently asked questions.

Common questions related to the Big Idea

I have taught the concept of the Big Idea and asked participants to practice it in the majority of workshops I've led over the past decade. As part of this, I've fielded many questions related to it. I'll share the common ones along with my thoughts and some related illustrative anecdotes.

I can't get it all into a single sentence. What should I do? Keep trying. Seriously. You can do it, and there are big benefits when you do. I'll rephrase a concern I raised before: if you can't clearly articulate your idea in a single sentence, how in the world are you going to put together a presentation that gets your message across to someone else? The Big Idea won't be the only thing you communicate. You will have supporting material, which is where additional details will come into play. We'll turn our attention there in Chapter 3. By first getting clear and succinct on your primary message, you put yourself in a much better position to form supportive content that will effectively convey it to others.

If you're struggling—even with the inclusion of creative punctuation like commas and semicolons—to get your key message down to a sentence, there are a few things to try. One approach is to start with more. Write as many sentences as necessary, then cull from there. This is one of the reasons I start this chapter with the 3-minute story. It's hard to go from everything to a single

sentence. Forming a highly condensed version that still preserves some context is a helpful interim step before you get fully succinct. Another strategy is to build the sentence piece by piece. Use the Big Idea worksheet to tackle a single component at a time, then pull it together. It's harder for extraneous information to sneak in following this method.

Won't negative framing for conveying what's at stake always be more effective? Focusing on the risks is certainly one way to light a fire, getting people to pay attention and promote action. But there are cases where negative framing may not be the best route. If it's already a highly emotionally charged situation, for example, tread lightly.

I recall a scenario when I worked at Google that illustrates such a case. Each year, we conducted an employee survey, where we asked questions about all sorts of dimensions related to the job and work environment, including a thorough section about managers.

I was tasked with walking a director, who had *awful* feedback from members of his team, through his survey results. The negative input didn't stop with low scores on the manager-related survey items but was supported by some scathing commentary. This is tough feedback to deliver and is definitely illustrative of a potentially emotionally charged situation. If I'd gone into this with negative framing ("You have a problem!"), I would have put the manager on the defensive, making it difficult to have a productive discussion. Instead, I highlighted the positive: how hard but extremely helpful it is to get candid feedback and the resources available to help him. This meant we could spend time reflecting and putting the initial building blocks of an action plan into place. It was a difficult conversation, but one that was made a little bit easier for both of us given the thought I'd put into framing ahead of time. I kept one thing top of mind above all else: my audience.

If you're ever unsure whether positive or negative framing will work best, think through both. Then reflect on which one will more likely achieve your desired results. If you are still uncertain, talk it over with someone else.

Be aware also that you may have a personal tendency for positive or negative framing. This is not related to being considered a positive or negative person but instead is driven by how you are best motivated. I tend to have an easier time with positive framing because I've always been motivated by pleasing others.

It isn't only personal proclivities that play into this, but organizational culture as well. I've had some interesting discussions about this idea with workshop attendees. The way organizations communicate in general influences which framing—positive (benefits) or negative (risks)—comes more naturally, as well as what is likely to be better accepted by others in the organization. In one workshop, a participant described the organizational culture as overwhelmingly supportive and collaborative. Those in the room could all succinctly describe the core company values. They were in general agreement that negatively framing the Big Idea would backfire in this environment. That might be true, but it may also be an opportunity to get attention by doing something out of the norm. There's no single right approach here. However, it is imperative that you are aware of the perspective you are taking and why.

What if my audience doesn't care about what's at stake? I've had numerous conversations with people crafting the Big Idea who have grappled with this question. In nearly every case, the challenge was that the person was focusing on what mattered to *them*, rather than what mattered to *their audience*. If you position things right, others will naturally care because you will have made it personal for them.

The tip I touched on earlier to play things out to extremes is sometimes helpful here and can be useful to do in both positive and negative directions. The positive direction would go something like this: if the action I want taken happens, this thing follows (that's good); then as a result, this other thing transpires (that's great). Continue with this until you get world peace, world domination, or whatever your ultimate goal might be. Doing this in the negative direction ends in the ultimate doomsday scenario. Are either of these conclusions likely to play out? No. The learning is in the exercise, then figuring out how to back up to a position that is appropriate framing for what is at stake in the given situation.

This final point is important. Thoughtfully assess what will be pertinent, but avoid going overly extreme with your audience. I once had a conversation with a workshop participant after doing the Big Idea activity where we both had an “aha” moment. Let’s call her Kate. Kate worked on an audit team and had been trying to get her colleagues to prepare for blockchain (the digital ledger in which transactions made in bitcoin or another cryptocurrency are recorded publicly). Kate believed that the audit profession as a whole would be in danger unless they took actions to prepare for the future in regard to this. Her challenge was getting anyone to listen to her. She read her Big Idea to me, which basically said (I’m paraphrasing): “You are going to become obsolete, and the audit profession as a whole is destined to end as a result of blockchain; you must take action now to prepare for it!”

Let’s think back to my worst-case scenario advice. Kate had done this. The challenge was that she hadn’t backed up from there appropriately. The entire profession failing and everyone losing their job tomorrow was such an unlikely outcome that she was easy to ignore. As we talked about this, I witnessed Kate’s pivotal moment when she understood why she wasn’t getting a positive response.

The solution? We discussed reputational risk and perceptions in the organization, and Kate thought these would be better for conveying what was at stake for this group in a way that would cause them to want to listen to her and act in the near term.

Will my Big Idea have numbers in it? One reason the Big Idea is short is that it forces you to let go of many of the details, including numbers. Frequently, the Big Idea will not have a number in it. Unless there is a figure that’s going to be particularly compelling or sticky (easy to remember), you’ll typically want to concentrate on the words and ideas—not the numbers. Notice in my rewrite of the Big Idea I shared earlier, I removed the numbers altogether and instead highlighted the action I want my audience to take. This parlays nicely into the next common question.

Should my Big Idea have the action in it? If your audience walks out of the room at the end of your meeting or presentation—what is the thing they remember? This is one way to think about the Big Idea. If there is an action you want people to take (as we’ve discussed, there ought to be), then yes, it belongs in the Big Idea. Note that this won’t always be as simple as, “We found X; therefore, you must do Y.” The action can take countless forms: a discussion you’d like your stakeholders to have, a decision they should make, options to weigh, or an understanding you require from them. Be clear on the step you want your audience to take and thoughtfully integrate it into your Big Idea.

I don’t simply have a single idea to get across. I have a number of things to convey. How do I do this? People are much more likely to remember one or two key points than a laundry list of items. If many actions are desired, one way to tackle it is to make the Big Idea something broader that connects them: *We need to prioritize and assign ownership of the 20 action items in order to... or, Without budget approval for our key initiatives, we run the risk of...*

Your audience may not be able to recall the key initiatives, and they definitely won’t remember the 20 action items. They actually don’t have to. They’ll have supporting documentation to refer back to if necessary. But it is important for your audience to remember what you need most from them. In reframing, think about what they must remember and act upon, noting how to structure your Big Idea to best accomplish that.

I am facing a mixed audience—how do I deal with this? Mixed groups are a difficult challenge, as we discussed in Chapter 1. The individuals that comprise them often care about different things. This makes it hard to compose a single sentence that applies to everyone. Still, there are a few things you can do. Narrow by focusing on the decision makers. Group people according to what matters to them, look for areas of overlap, and communicate from those intersections. Formulate the Big Idea separately for your different audiences, then figure out whether there is a single Big Idea that can be formed from them.

What I’ve outlined are the most common questions raised in a workshop setting related to the Big Idea. One way to answer these questions as well as

others that arise as you create your own Big Idea is to talk through it with someone else. Let's talk about the important role of feedback.

Seek feedback

Once you've taken the time to formulate the Big Idea—whether by writing and condensing or through use of the Big Idea worksheet—the subsequent critical step is to discuss with another person. When practicing the Big Idea in a live setting, I give the instruction: "Partners, your job is very important. Ask the person sharing their Big Idea a *ton* of questions. Help them get clear and concise on their message." People are always surprised at how helpful this short conversation is for helping clarify their thinking.

Seeking feedback from someone else is super important because it helps you to get out of your head. Over time, you develop a good deal of tacit knowledge about the area in which you work. It's hard to imagine that others aren't working from that same set of information and assumptions. This means it's relatively easy to formulate something that makes total sense to you but that sounds completely foreign to someone else. This is one reason getting feedback is important. The person you seek out to do this doesn't need to be familiar with your project. On the contrary, it is helpful to discuss with someone who does not have context given the queries they will pose. The basic questions of "Who?," "How?," and "So what?" prompt you to express your logic and thought process. Doing this leads to productive conversations and gives you insights to further refine your Big Idea.

Generate the Big Idea in a team setting

The Big Idea is a fantastic exercise to do when you are working on something as part of a team. Have individuals first independently formulate their Big Idea. Then write each idea on a whiteboard or in a shared document (the latter works well for geographically dispersed teams). Simply seeing different approaches together can be a great way to know that people are in alignment or identify when they are not.

Take the time as a team to discuss and form a master Big Idea. This process is beneficial for a few reasons. First, the resulting Big Idea is likely superior to any individually crafted one. People invariably tackle the sentence differently; there's value in having multiple approaches, words, and phrases from which to pull. It helps create buy-in and ownership as individuals see pieces of their work being incorporated into the final version. The topics of discussion that arise out of this process also tend to be informative and establish that everyone is clear and consistent when it comes to overall message and goal.

Next, I'll illustrate these concepts through an example.

Craft your message: TRIX case study

Let's revisit the market research scenario introduced at the end of Chapter 1.

As a reminder, my team has been contracted by the prominent food manufacturer, Nosh, to conduct research and advise modifications to their popular TRIX trail mix to reduce cost without negatively impacting consumer sentiment. We've just wrapped up the project and are planning the communication that I will present to the client team at Nosh outlining our findings and recommendations. The desired outcome is a well-informed discussion and clear decision on what changes to make to trail mix ingredients and packaging, with the senior stakeholders in the group sufficiently impressed to advocate that Nosh shift future business to our firm.

I start by outlining the components of the overarching story for this situation—the plot, twist, and ending.

1. **Plot:** Given the rising cost of TRIX ingredients, the mix needs to be modified.
2. **Twist:** Neither alternative mix tested as well with consumers as the original mix.
3. **Ending:** There are still good options to consider; let's discuss and set next steps.

Given these components (plus some additional details that I'll impart to you now), I formulate the following 3-minute story:

The cost of macadamia nuts—a key ingredient in the popular TRIX trail mix—is on the rise. Nosh engaged us to advise changes to the product that will lower cost without sacrificing consumer preference. We've thoroughly analyzed the competitive market and performed research that included the design, execution, and analysis of a series of tests to understand consumer preference across a variety of dimensions of the current TRIX trail mix related to alternative recipes and packaging.

When it comes to ingredients, none of the alternative mixes scored as strongly with consumers as the original recipe; however, there are still good options to consider. We believe another mix that wasn't directly tested but incorporates learnings from those that were could be the winning combination when it comes to both reduced cost and high customer satisfaction. That said, your risk tolerance will play into the decision at hand.

There are a few options to weigh. If consumer sentiment can't be jeopardized, you can maintain it by sticking with the existing mix. To make that sustainable given current and expected ingredient costs, you'd have to raise consumer price to make it work, which we're not confident the market will support. You could go directly to market with the new alternative mix I mentioned, which would reduce macadamia nuts and introduce flaked coconut. This has some risk associated with it since it hasn't been explicitly tested. Another option is to run additional tests and analysis to fully vet this recommended mix or additional alternatives, though that has the drawback of both additional cost and time.

We also did research and testing with product packaging. A new option that incorporates a view window through which the product is directly visible was preferred. We understand there are marketing collateral concerns when it

comes to changing the look of the product. However, intent to purchase is higher with the view window. Making a change to this has the potential to help the product appeal to a wider customer base at no long-term increase in cost to manufacture.

Given all of this, let's discuss and determine where you'd like to go from here.

I'll expand upon this 3-minute story in Chapter 3, when I brainstorm detailed content to support it. Before I do that, I'll condense it into a clear and concise single statement: the Big Idea.

When it comes to the key message, there is a decision to make regarding how forward to be with a given recommendation. This is something that is frequently worth weighing when determining how to message our communications, and it plays into how we frame our Big Idea. Do we simply suggest a menu of potential options without any stated preference, or push for the one we personally think is best?

Let's apply this question to the scenario we're working through here. One option would be to simply outline the various potential changes to TRIX trail mix for our client group to consider and let them discuss and decide—similar to how I framed the 3-minute story. As another approach, I could make a clear recommendation on what course of action *I believe they should take* based on my point of view. Both have their merits and downsides, and which makes the most sense will be highly situationally driven.

In this case—given the great stakes when it comes to potentially winning this client's future business—I want to be bold. I will present them with options but also a clear recommendation for a course of action based on my expertise in this space and informed by the robust research my team has conducted. It's a little risky, but I decide it is a worthwhile gamble given what I stand to gain if all goes well.

Before sharing my Big Idea, I encourage you to look back at the Big Idea worksheet (Figure 2.1) in light of all of this context and ponder how you'd respond to the individual questions. After you've given this some thought (and perhaps even made some notes!), check out Figure 2.2, which shows my completed Big Idea worksheet.

the **BIG IDEA** worksheet

Identify a project you are working on where you need to communicate in a data-driven way. Reflect upon and fill out the following.

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PROJECT TRIX Market Research

WHO IS YOUR AUDIENCE?

(1) List the primary groups or individuals to whom you'll be communicating.

Stakeholders at Nosh:

- Vanessa + Matt (product)
- Jack + Shannon (finance)
- Riley (marketing)
- Charlie (cust. satisfaction)
- Abbey + Simon (R&D)

(2) If you had to narrow that to a single person, who would that be?

Vanessa (head of product)

(3) What does your audience care about?

- Reducing cost to produce TRIX
- Keeping high customer satisfaction
- Unknown: Risk tolerance

(4) What action does your audience need to take?

- Consider an untested option that incorporates research learnings
- Determine changes to TRIX ingredients & packaging

WHAT IS AT STAKE?

What are the benefits if your audience acts in the way that you want them to?

- reduced cost to manufacture
- maintain beloved ingredient
- delight consumers with revamped mix, positive brand impact

What are the risks if they do not?

- Current mix too costly to produce, reduced profits, demise of products
- Additional testing will delay, cost \$ and time

FORM YOUR BIG IDEA

It should:

(1) articulate your point of view,

(2) convey what's at stake, and

(3) be a complete (and single!) sentence.

Change the TRIX mix: don't eliminate the beloved macadamia nuts, reduce them, and also introduce coconut & modify packaging to balance cost and consumer sentiment.

FIGURE 2.2 The Big Idea worksheet for TRIX market research project

I enlist four colleagues at my market research firm who have been involved in the project to each complete the Big Idea worksheet and craft their respective Big Ideas. I put them all into a shared document. Here they are (you'll recognize the final one from my worksheet):

1. Macadamia nuts have become too expensive; product success will decline if you don't modify the ingredient mix to reduce the cost to produce TRIX trail mix.
2. There are differences in both manufacturing cost and consumer preference across the options tested for TRIX; let's discuss the tradeoffs and set future strategy.
3. We can reduce cost to produce by refreshing the TRIX blend and packaging.
4. Decide what's more important, cost to produce or consumer response, to determine whether to keep the current mix and increase price or go with a new alternative blend.
5. Change the TRIX mix: don't eliminate the beloved macadamia nuts, reduce them, and also introduce coconut and modify packaging to balance cost and consumer sentiment.

I have a meeting with my colleagues to review, discuss, and form a single master Big Idea. There is some interesting discussion about positive versus negative framing, after which we decide that the positive framing—highlighting what our audience stands to gain rather than what they might lose—sets a better tone for fruitful conversation. We also note that while some individuals focused mainly on cost in their Big Idea, others also brought in consumer sentiment. There is consensus that our client group cares highly about both of these elements and that they each warrant mentioning in the ultimate Big Idea. We also decide conclusively (after some healthy debate) that we'd like to be direct about recommending a specific course of action. Our Big Idea will encapsulate this, while the content we use to support it will include a robust

set of potential options with tradeoffs for our client to weigh as they decide which course of action to pursue.

Given all of this, my colleagues and I land on the following Big Idea after our thorough discussion and a good amount of patient wordsmithing:

Consider an alternative trail mix blend that balances consumer preference with the desire to lower cost by decreasing macadamia nuts, adding coconut, and modifying the packaging so potential buyers can see the product.

We agree that this is the main message we want to get across. We'll use the communication we eventually build with this in mind to facilitate a discussion around the specific tradeoffs with different courses of action and guide our stakeholders to make a decision regarding future strategy for TRIX trail mix.

Keep this example in mind—we'll return to it in the upcoming chapter.

As we've discussed, once you've taken the time to form your Big Idea, you have a litmus test for any content you contemplate including in your ultimate communication. Simply ask yourself, "Does this help me get my Big Idea across?" Speaking of planning content, let's do that next.



chapter 3

compile the pieces

In the previous chapter, I asked you to let go of a lot of detail in order to get succinct on your message. That may have felt uncomfortable. I'll venture to guess that it *did* feel uncomfortable. But don't worry. Now is when you get to think about your communication more broadly, including the various supporting elements that will help you get your message across.

In this chapter, I'll walk you through the process to create your plan of attack—a storyboard. We'll start by brainstorming and spend time generating ideas and enumerating potential pieces of content. Then we'll edit, arrange, and rearrange. We'll seek and incorporate feedback. All of this will culminate in an initial and robust plan for your presentation content.

What is a storyboard?

Storyboarding is a term I've appropriated for the business setting. A storyboard is a sequence of drawings that represent shots planned for a movie, television show, or commercial (for many people, this word conjures TV's *Mad Men*-style advertisement sketches). For use in the business world, I simply think of the storyboard as a visual outline for presentation content. You don't have to be an artist to reap the immense benefits of this strategy. In addition to organizing your thoughts and creating a plan that keeps you on track, taking the time to storyboard as part of the planning process often leads to shorter, targeted, and more effective communications.

The first piece of advice I have for you when it comes to everything we'll discuss in this chapter: keep it low tech. Let's begin with this.

Learn to love low tech

Resist any urge to turn to your tools at this point! This is not the right time to open PowerPoint, Google Slides, or Keynote and start making slides. We still have a good amount of work to do before then, and it will be entirely low tech. We will use pens, paper, and sticky notes.

Let's look at the reasons we sometimes use technology prematurely and the unintended negative consequences that will lead you to appreciate the benefits of staying low tech. First, there is a sense of accomplishment when we create in our tools. Making a slide *feels* productive. Expanding on this, making a lot of slides feels like great progress! Despite that, when you do this too soon, it can be counterproductive. You may spend time creating content that ends up not being right for the situation. A single unnecessary slide probably isn't the

end of the world. But consider the case where you go into slide-generating mode and create an entire deck that doesn't get your Big Idea across. This is remarkably easy to do. The low-tech part of the process helps us to avoid this by ensuring every bit of content has been thoroughly vetted. This leads to my next point.

Another reason we are sometimes drawn to our computers is for the level of polish that comes with what we create. To a large degree, people have stopped writing with pen and paper. This can make doing so feel awkward and slow. Perhaps you don't consider yourself good at drawing or think you have sloppy handwriting—but if you are able to easily mock something up in PowerPoint, you might as well do that, right? No! This action is understandable, but there is a place for rough ideas, poor penmanship, bad sketches, and simply the process of committing pen to paper. As we put each of these things out into the world, we are testing content. We are thinking about it critically. In response to an idea you've written, you can feel your own reaction and solicit that of others in a way that focuses on the *meta approach* instead of the specific content (once a slide exists, it begs for the content and design to be critiqued; we'll need that, too, but at a later point). What we require first is a well-structured plan of attack.

Additionally, remaining low tech as we plan helps us avoid the attachment trap. Have you ever noticed that once you take the time to build something—a slide, for example—you develop a certain fondness toward it? In some cases, even if you know it could be better or would benefit from change, you might resist *because of the work it's already taken you to get it where it is*. Let's say I've just spent four hours creating a beautiful graph on a fantastic slide. I'm walking you through the deck, and we get to this particular slide. You say to me, "Cole, I don't think this one is relevant. Maybe you should push it to the appendix?"

This feels bad.

There are feelings of *loss* associated with this.

There is *real* loss associated with this when we take into account the four hours of work it took me to create the beautiful graph on the fantastic slide.

Now assume that I've remained low tech. I resisted the urge to open my laptop. I did not create any slides. Instead, I brainstormed ideas on sticky notes and organized them into a storyboard. Let's take the same scenario: I'm walking you through this plan, and we get to a sticky note that features a rough sketch of the graph I have in mind. You point out that it isn't relevant. I reflect on this, realize you're right, and recycle it. I didn't form attachment to or fondness toward the sticky note. There wasn't any feeling of loss involved. Nor was there time wasted creating and subsequently discarding content or relinquishing it to an appendix.

While working with presentation software makes you feel powerful and in control as you easily create slides, the low-tech planning is where the real magic happens. Let's take a closer look at how to do this, beginning with a brainstorm.

Brainstorm

I storyboard any time I'm going to cover new content or present something in a different way. I encourage you to do so, too. This active planning step helps you avoid doing things the way you've always done them out of habit by forcing you to critically consider the circumstances for a given situation.

Storyboarding best begins with a brainstorm, which for me always feels like a cathartic process. The goal is simply to generate ideas. Start writing. As you produce ideas, don't worry about whether the various topics will make it into your final deck or in what order they will appear. First, simply get your thoughts out of your head and into the physical world. Do this for a limited amount of time. For me, 10–15 minutes of concentrated brainstorming is typically sufficient. Then ideas will continue to arise as I work through the other parts of the storyboarding process.

My favorite storyboarding tool: sticky notes

I storyboard using small sticky notes. I opt for the 1 $\frac{7}{8}$ inch (47.6 mm) squares and have them in a variety of colors that I'll sometimes use to categorize as I go along. I like sticky notes for their petite size, which forces me to be concise with my ideas. I also appreciate their stick to keep them in place as I begin to organize, which we'll discuss in the editing step.

Too constrained by sticky notes?

While I advocate using sticky notes for brainstorming and arranging ideas into a storyboard, they are certainly not your only option. I have friends who swear that index cards are the best tool for planning (they are just as easy to rearrange, *and* you can pack them up neatly with a loop or two of a rubber band for presentation planning on the go!). Once, in a workshop, a participant told me that sticky notes made them nervous. They felt too restricted because they were used to brainstorming on a full piece of paper (this method is totally fine, though I'd recommend cutting up the paper afterwards so you can move the pieces around). More important than the tool are the mechanics. The goal is to think critically about the content that will help you get your message across and arrange things in a way that will make sense for your audience. Use whatever device will help you do all of this with ease.

We'll get more detailed about what to put on a sticky note momentarily, but when I brainstorm, I usually write down topics and content ideas. As I brainstormed for this chapter of this book, my sticky notes focused on specific section titles and subsection content. When brainstorming for a presentation, imagine that each note eventually becomes a slide in your deck. But allow yourself flexibility: some single-idea stickies may become multiple slides, or you might combine several into a single slide. This will become clear when you edit. At the onset, it's mainly about generating a good number of ideas.

Change your environment for a creativity boost

The environment in which you brainstorm and storyboard has an impact. I work at a large black desk in the middle of my office, seated at a stool. When I storyboard, I physically stand up and walk around to the other side of the desk. It's a wide-open surface (practically begging to be filled with my ideas!). There's something about having a different visual perspective and standing as I do this that helps stimulate my creativity. After I've brainstormed and arranged my ideas, I get a large piece of paper and transfer the sticky notes to it. This allows me to carry the plan back around to the computer side of my desk for when I start to write or create slides.

If you're ever feeling stuck, try changing your physical environment to spark new ideas.

What do I put on a sticky note?

I've said to generate ideas, but that's pretty general guidance. Precisely what kind of ideas, you might ask? There isn't a single *right* way to storyboard. You'll figure out what works for you by trying it and adjusting as you go through the process.

When I'm brainstorming, the sorts of things I write on my stickies tend to fall into the following categories:

- Historical or environmental context
- The problem statement, question, or hypothesis
- My Big Idea
- Assumptions I've made
- Biases to address

- Data points
- Graphs or other visuals
- Analysis details or statistical methodology
- Process steps
- Illustrative examples
- Findings or takeaways
- Alternative hypotheses
- Options to consider
- Discussion points
- Recommendations

This is a good place to pause and try it out. Do you have a current project where you need to communicate something to someone? Get yourself a stack of stickies or cut up blank paper. Set a timer for ten minutes. Using my list as a guide, brainstorm ideas for potential content that will help you get your message across.

Consider various perspectives

Most of the brainstorming we do is from our own perspective. Like communicating for yourself, as we've discussed, this is a natural—and reasonable—place to start. But it's not the right point to stop. We spent a good deal of time reflecting on your audience in Chapter 1. It wouldn't make sense to ignore them now as we plan our content!

After you've taken time to brainstorm for yourself, assume a different lens. Begin by imagining the viewpoint of your audience. Revisit the Big Idea that you formed in Chapter 2, and think about what *they* would want to know or see to better understand your message or be motivated to act in the way you want them to. If you're communicating to a mixed group, do this several times, assuming different perspectives from which to brainstorm and generate additional ideas. There may be other positions to take into account as well.

Assume the point of view of a colleague, your manager, or another stakeholder. When it comes time to edit, one strategy will be to look for areas of overlap. Use those to create common ground and ensure the robust set of priorities are met.

Speaking of editing, once you've generated a ton of ideas—and perhaps even started to arrange and discard some of them—it is time to edit.

Edit: refine and rearrange

After brainstorming, take a step back. Begin to curate your ideas, picking out the ones that best suit specific needs. This editing step typically takes longer than the brainstorming part did, and you may continue to generate ideas as you work your way through it.

Think about what framework could help you pull everything together in a way that will make sense to someone else. How will you organize and order the content? Add new stickies to categorize themes and start to arrange. Where might you benefit from transitional content? Add notes. Are there opportunities to combine similar ideas or topics that could be aggregated in the same section? Put those stickies together, and perhaps add a topic to group them. Identify where to incorporate data or illustrative examples. Continue to rearrange, physically lifting and moving sticky notes around. Add new ideas when necessary. Crumple up the ones that don't serve your purpose.

The importance of intentional discard

On the topic of eliminating, let's pause to discuss one of the biggest benefits of storyboarding: intentional discard. When we start in our tools (like PowerPoint or Keynote), in addition to the issues I outlined earlier in this chapter, another problem is the false belief that what we create must answer any question that arises. Whereas when we start low tech, we can be thoughtful about each piece of potential content we consider including and ask ourselves an

important question: does this help me get my Big Idea across? No? Cut it. Start a discard pile. Add to it without hesitation.

When I storyboard, I always have a discard pile. I'll sometimes write down the same idea five times and discard it five times because it takes this repetition for me to convince myself that it (whatever *it* is) doesn't belong in the communication. If the idea has come up this many times, it's probably good to know the content or answer to the question in the event it arises, but not every bit of relevant information has to have a home in my presentation. This process of intentional discard leads to shorter, more effective communications.

Storyboard at different levels for longer content

For longer presentations or written content, I often storyboard multiple times and at different levels over the course of time. This typically starts broad and then becomes increasingly granular as I plan the particulars. Let's take this book as an example.

First, I storyboarded the overall structure: the main sections and chapters (it was an iterative method rather than a linear one to get everything to align in a way that made sense to me). In some cases, I'd go a little deeper into content ideas for a given chapter to get a sense of overall balance and to keep track of the thoughts I had on what would best fit into a given area. As I write these words, the high-level plan lives in a readily visible sticky note outline on my office closet door. I reflect on it and periodically make adjustments (while I'm mostly set now on what I'm writing about in the *plan* chapters that include this one, I'm rethinking how to structure the *create* chapters that come next).

While that's happening at the meta level, I'm also focusing on a given chapter at a time. I start each by storyboarding. I brainstorm and then arrange section topics, content ideas, sidebars, illustrative examples, and

anecdotes. For my writing, I don't generally solicit feedback at this point (whereas I often will if it's a presentation that I'm planning). If I'm unsure about the arrangement or approach, I'll talk through it aloud to work it out. Then I start writing, using the chapter storyboard I've created as my guide. There are points where I'll still get stuck and go back to the storyboard, rearrange, and then try again. However, most often at this point, the editing shifts to the written document (and continues there for quite some time!).

A similar strategy also works for longer presentations. Start by storyboarding the general layout and have this be your overarching guide. Then storyboard again at varying levels of granularity so you are able to see and vet your plan before committing to it and creating content. After storyboarding your general content, repeat the process for a given section. You may storyboard *again* to plan the content for a given slide. Yes, this takes time and effort. But as we've discussed, the amount of thought this forces you to put into everything will raise the quality of what you create and guide you to craft communications that better suit the given situation.

Where should my Big Idea appear in my storyboard?

When it comes to arranging content, one common set of questions that arises is, "Where do I put my Big Idea in my storyboard? Do I build up to it? Lead with it? Something else?" There's no single right path. Different scenarios will call for varying approaches. In some cases, these disparate methods will work equally well. There are a few things to take into account related to the placement of your Big Idea and general ordering of the components of your storyboard.

Frequently, when we initially arrange our content, it follows a chronological or linear fashion. This tends to come most naturally because that is the

same general order as our experience. If I'm communicating the results of an analysis, I can start out with the question I set out to answer, then talk about the data I used (where it came from, what I did to clean it, etc.). Next, I could review the specifics of the analysis I undertook. This leads into my findings and recommendations. This progression comes as a matter of course; it's the same way I tackled the project.

When we arrange our content in a linear fashion such as this, the Big Idea typically comes at the end. This means we have to keep our audience's attention until the finale to get to our main point. Another option is to begin with the Big Idea. But what if we do that and others disagree with us? That might not be the best way to start. This leads me to some specific considerations to keep in mind as you determine where to put your Big Idea within your broader presentation.

One factor is the level of credibility you have with your audience. If you do not have a strong relationship with them and you start with your Big Idea *and they disagree*, you begin from a position of discord. This is not typically a fantastic starting point. In that case, going through the chronological ordering—the linear progression—could be a better option, so you bring others along with your logic as you go through it. By the time you get to the end, they are hopefully bought in or at least willing to listen.

On the other hand, there are scenarios when it absolutely makes sense to lead with the Big Idea. For example, if you already have established rapport or you think your audience is likely to accept what you recommend, starting with the Big Idea gets everyone into the right frame of mind and more quickly sets up productive conversations. You can also lead with the Big Idea if you're not sure you have time to go through everything from beginning to end or if you fear someone will interrupt and take you off track. If your audience cares more about the ultimate "So what?" than how you got there—then by all means, lead with the Big Idea. In some cases, if others buy in at the onset, you won't have to go through the rest of the details.

Generally, contemplate what order you anticipate working best given the specific situation: who your audience is and how you'll be presenting to them. Don't get too attached to your storyboard yet. We'll look at additional strategies for ordering content in Chapter 4 when we discuss story. At that point, I'll encourage you to return to your storyboard and make changes. Before we do that, though, this is a good place to pause and get input from someone else.

Solicit feedback

Getting feedback on your storyboard has benefits similar to receiving input on the Big Idea. There are advantages to talking through it out loud, articulating your logic, and answering questions to help assess whether what you're planning makes sense to someone else. After crafting your storyboard, grab a colleague and spend 10–15 minutes walking through it, discussing it, and getting feedback.

This early planning point is also often an excellent place to get client, stakeholder, or manager feedback. This isn't always possible and won't make sense every time, but when it does, it's an opportunity to make sure everyone is aligned before you've done a great deal of work. Preface your request with, "This is rough, but here's what I'm thinking," sharing your actual storyboard or even a bulleted list that walks through your plans. If you can get feedback indicating, "Yes, this is great, keep going," or "No, this isn't it; we should change direction," you haven't wasted a ton of time and effort. In general, the earlier in the process you get this type of directional feedback, the better. Flipping that around, if you are a manager of others and would like to be able to give feedback earlier in the process, encourage your team members to craft storyboards to share with you.

Storyboard as a team

Storyboarding as a team is an excellent exercise, particularly in the instance where multiple individuals will contribute to a deck or report. If you can, get everyone into a conference room with a whiteboard and markers. After you have agreement on general content and flow, draw large slide-shaped

rectangles on the whiteboard (the oversized roughly slide-proportioned sticky notes are also fun to implement during team storyboarding, where each sticky note represents a slide). Add draft titles and sketch the supporting content to be gathered or created.

In this manner, everyone walks away with the same overall vision. It also allows people to understand how what they are tasked with will fit into the big picture, assists individuals giving each other feedback, and encourages cohesion across the communication. It helps ensure everyone is on the same page in terms of the deliverable.

Team storyboarding in a non-located environment

Getting everyone in a room with a whiteboard works great when you're all in the same office. But what happens when you need to storyboard as a team in a non-located environment? In this case, emulate the sticky note approach. Any type of shared document that multiple people are able to view and edit simultaneously can work for this (in Google Docs, your storyboard may look more like a bulleted list, which is fine). There are also applications that mirror this process, such as Miro, Evernote, or Microsoft OneNote. For smaller scale or free solutions, check out Storyboard That or Padlet.

Depending on your technology, sometimes brute force also works. For example, put ideas in large text on slides, then go to slide sorter view. Share the screen in a virtual meeting to drive discussion, moving around pieces to reflect the conversation. I also recall situations at Google where we'd have colleagues in the office and joining via video conference, and those physically present would aim the camera at the whiteboard where we were storyboarding so that everyone could participate.

Now that we've discussed how to storyboard, let's see it illustrated.

Compile the pieces: TRIX case study

Recall the example we've been working through at the close of each chapter.

As a reminder, my team has been contracted by the prominent food manufacturer, Nosh, to conduct research and advise modifications to their popular TRIX trail mix to reduce cost without negatively impacting consumer sentiment. We've recently wrapped up the project and are planning the communication that I will present to the client team at Nosh outlining our findings and recommendations. The desired outcome is a well-informed discussion and clear decision on what changes to make to trail mix ingredients and packaging, with the senior stakeholders in the group sufficiently impressed to advocate that Nosh shift future business to our firm.

Together with my colleagues, I've already crafted the Big Idea for our communication: *Consider an alternative trail mix blend that balances consumer preference with the desire to lower cost by decreasing macadamia nuts, adding coconut, and modifying the packaging so potential buyers can see the product.* This is the key point we want to get across to our audience. The actual communication will be a slide deck that I will present in a meeting. I will use it to convey the findings of our research and put forth our specific recommendation in context of a set of options for the stakeholders to discuss and set strategy for the TRIX trail mix product.

I begin by brainstorming. I get out mini sticky notes and start writing down ideas. I think through the project from beginning to end—from the context that led us to work with Nosh in the first place all the way through to the recommendation and Big Idea. Due to this approach, my idea generation is linear in nature (roughly mirroring the progression of the project that was undertaken). After doing this from my perspective, I attempt to assume various stakeholders' views and generate content ideas specific to their preferences as well. What will Vanessa (Head of Product) care about most, or what level of detail will Jack (divisional CFO) require to be satisfied? What information will Abbey and Simon (R&D) expect to be convinced that our methodology is sound?

After about 15 minutes of writing ideas and assuming multiple perspectives, I have a lot of sticky notes in front of me. Given the volume, instead of showing them all, I'll list what I've written on the various notes to give you a sense of quantity, breadth, and depth.

- Pilot project aims to assess ongoing partnership
- TRIX is Nosh's popular trail mix snack product
- TRIX sales over time (demonstrate success)
- Ingredients: macadamias, almonds, cashews, dried cherries, dark chocolate
- Desire to lower cost to manufacture
- Important: maintain high consumer preference
- Options explored: change size, price, packaging, ingredients
- Data: product sizes
- Data: packaging options
- Data: competitor pricing
- Data: competitor ingredients
- Component cost analysis
- Finding: macadamia nuts are expensive
- Price sensitivity analysis
- Finding: market not likely to bear higher price point
- Packaging cost analysis
- Finding: alter packaging at negligible incremental cost
- Ran tests with consumers to understand preferences
- Study 1: packaging testing
- Study 1: alternative packaging tested
- Study 1 details: locations, timing, participant demographics
- Intent to purchase data & analysis
- Finding: view window increases intent to purchase

- Study 2: taste tests
- Study 2: alternative mixes tested
- Study 2 details: locations, timing, participant demographics
- Preference scores data & analysis
- Finding: original mix preferred overall
- Finding: alternative A scores low on appearance & texture
- Finding: alternative B scores low on taste
- Finding: people love coconut
- What's more important: cost or preference?
- Nosh's risk tolerance?
- We didn't test a magic mix, but we do have good options
- Big idea: reduce nuts, add coconut, and modify packaging
- Other options: increase price, do more testing
- Discuss
- Determine next steps

If I had started in PowerPoint, I could have easily created a slide (or more!) for each of the preceding bullets. While the resulting presentation would probably make sense to me, given my intimacy with the project, it would be tough to take someone else through sensibly. While my team needed to process all of this context, data, and analysis to gain a full understanding of the situation and make an informed recommendation, my audience doesn't have to see every step we took along the way. Instead, I will curate these ideas into a path along which I'll guide them.

To achieve that, I start editing. Now that I see all of the ideas for potential content in front of me, I consider what framework I can use to organize the pieces. I start a discard pile and put stickies there that may not be directly relevant or help me get my Big Idea across. There isn't a single way to organize the ideas—this can be achieved in a number of ways. As I make decisions about what to include and how to structure it, I keep my audience and how

I'll ultimately communicate to them in mind. I imagine what success looks like, and then in light of the ideas in front of me, weigh different ways to pull them together to actualize it.

After I've spent some time rearranging and organizing, the final step is to solicit feedback. I talk through my storyboard with my colleagues. This is also a good point to seek input from someone less involved with the project or perhaps a friendly stakeholder who can provide insight on what the group will be expecting and assess whether my plan makes sense. Thinking about the specific audience members we described in Chapter 1, Matt, Vanessa's chief of staff in the Product organization, would be a good person to turn to for this.

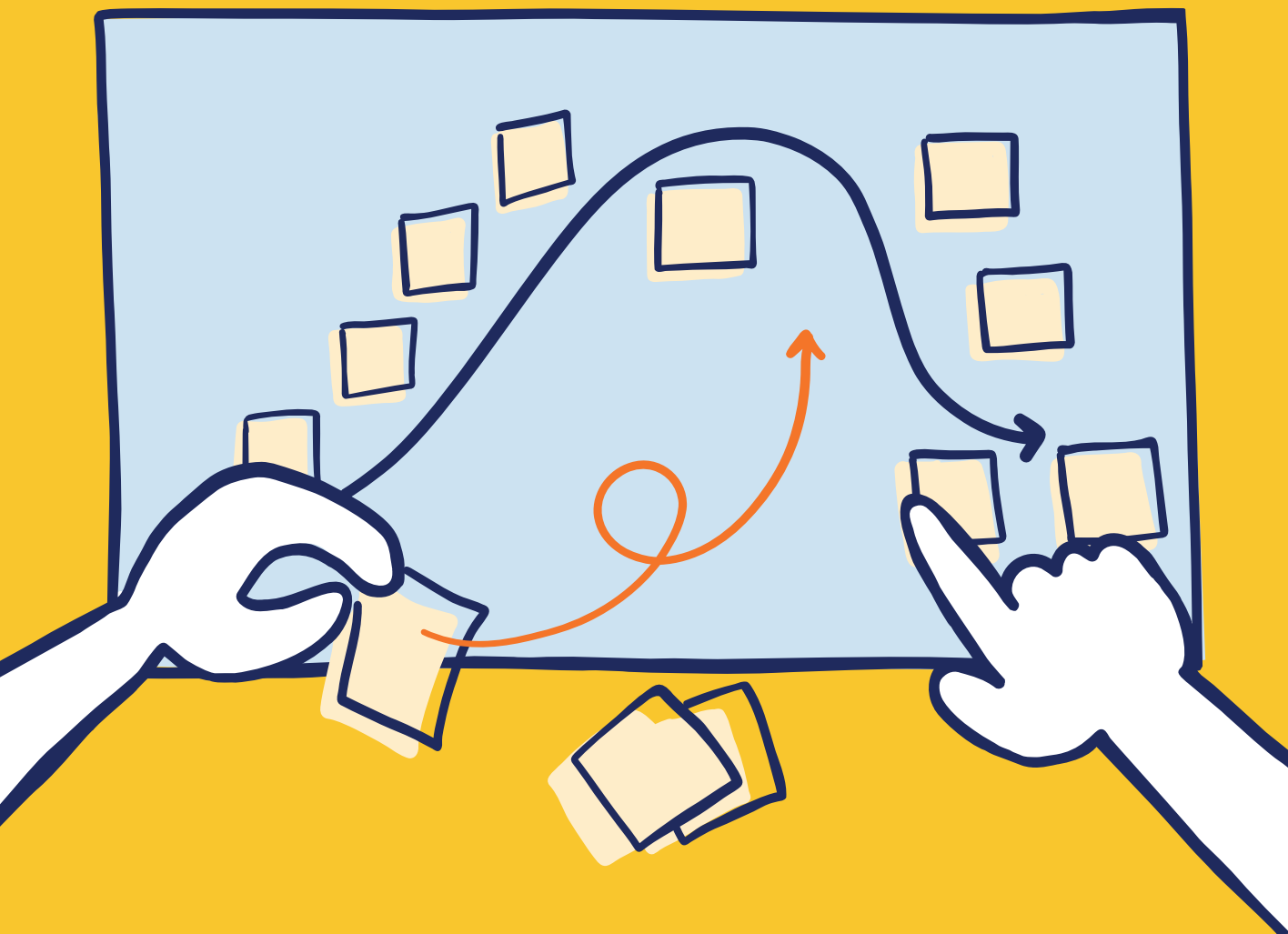
After sharing my plan with several individuals (including Matt) and continuing to refine, Figure 3.1 shows my resulting storyboard.



FIGURE 3.1 Storyboard for TRIX market research project

I chose to lead with the Big Idea. The three blue stickies denote the main sections of the communication. These could turn into divider slides in the eventual deck. The initial section sets the context. I'll begin with the background on why we were engaged in the first place. From there, I will show the results of the various studies we designed and conducted. This will transition into the following section that highlights our learnings. At this point, I can convey data and analysis that yielded the various findings and how we think they should be put to use. Finally, I'll focus my audience on action. I'll frame a conversation on the relative importance of consumer preference weighed against cost. I'll reiterate our team's recommendation and also share a full set of options for the stakeholders to weigh and discuss. All of this will lead to their informed decision about the future strategy of the TRIX trail mix.

We've brainstormed, edited, rearranged, and iterated given input. While we could stop here with our planning, there is another important concept to discuss first: story. Story helps us bring our approach to an entirely new level. Let's pivot our attention to that next.



form a story

You've identified your audience, formed your message, and crafted your plan. Before we start building content, though, let's pause to spend time contemplating *story* and explore how we can incorporate the art of storytelling into our communications. I'll begin by outlining a typical approach for business presentations, then contrast that with the potential power of structuring with story. After discussing how I think about story and its shape, I'll highlight the important role of tension and walk you through how to use the narrative arc as a model for restructuring and further refining the plan we set for our communication.

Why did we just spend all that time creating a storyboard only to change it now? you might ask. That's a reasonable question. However, the work I led you through in Chapter 3 was not for naught. Brainstorming potential content immersed you in the full details of the situation and caused you to look at the specifics from multiple points of view. As you edited your sticky notes, you had critical debates with yourself (and possibly, with others) on why to include some pieces and which topics or paths don't aptly serve your intended audience or message. You curated a vast array of possible content into something more targeted and manageable. These will be the building blocks for your story.

Additionally, through sharing your storyboard for feedback, you articulated your logic: the pieces of the puzzle you've chosen to focus on and how they fit together to serve your purpose. As a result, you are now in a position where

you are able to consider another structure precisely *because* of the thought you have put into everything thus far. The jump to story—and it is a jump, which we’ll talk more about—might indeed have been too large had you not gone through all of this work first.

Before we dive into story, let’s discuss a method that is often employed *instead*: the linear path.

A common approach: the linear path

The typical business presentation—whether communicated in a meeting or from a speaker on stage—often follows a predictable path. It begins with the background information to frame the topic or the context that led to the work that is being communicated. This may involve a problem statement that describes the purpose. Frequently, that’s followed by a recounting of the various activities undertaken or methodology employed. This could include the timeline and project scope, meetings held, experts consulted, data collected, analysis undertaken, and so on. After these specifics are fully detailed, they are followed by a summary of the lessons learned. The session ends with findings, recommendations, or next steps. Think back to the last presentation you sat through in a meeting or at a conference. Did it look something like this?



FIGURE 4.1 Typical business presentation linear path

There is nothing wrong with the linear path I’ve described, which is also depicted in Figure 4.1—but there’s not anything particularly awesome about it, either. I’ve been known to describe it as *selfish* on the part of the communicator to organize content in this manner. When I do so, I am being intentionally

provocative to make a point. This is the approach we tend to default to when we communicate because it mirrors the same steps, in roughly the same order, as we experienced during the project or process. It's chronological. It is logical. It feels familiar. I'll repeat a sentiment I mentioned early in the book: it's easy for me to communicate for myself. But is that framing particularly inspiring or memorable for others?

You know that the answer is no. You've been in the audience, suffering through presentations like this in the past. A key thing was missing in that instance—you. One failing of the linear path to explanatory communication is that we are able to follow it perfectly while simultaneously giving little or no thought to the people to whom we are communicating. This can yield a resulting communication that is ineffective for our audience. That's a problem!

Contrast that with story. Stories have a pronounced shape, involving the audience in a climactic rise and fall. Stories appeal to us on an emotional level. Stories engage. All of this together renders communications that follow a story structure much more interesting than the logic-inspired flat line of the linear path. Let's explore *story*, beginning with some discussion of what exactly I mean when I say that word.

What is story?

Story, storyteller, storytelling—these concepts have long existed but relatively recently become business buzzwords. They are thrown around frequently and loosely. While I love that communicating with story has become a legitimate topic of discussion, the overuse and misuse of these terms also dilutes what story truly is, misinforming how it can be used.

When I think about story as it relates to communicating in a business setting, I really mean *story*. I often refer to children's books to illustrate. Why? They are relatable. Every adult has a personal childhood experience they can draw upon to engage with my explanation. Some have children they read to on a nightly basis. Children's stories also often perfectly illustrate what I mean when

I say *story*. There is a plot: characters and a sense of place and time. Something occurs that throws things out of balance. There are ups and downs as the story progresses. These things-gone-wrong draw us in and keep us paying attention to find out what happens. By the end, the issues have typically been overcome or resolved in some way. Stories I've used to discuss these concepts include *The Cat in the Hat*, *Where the Wild Things Are*, *Harold and the Purple Crayon*, *Red Riding Hood*, *The Wizard of Oz*, *Charlotte's Web*, and recent favorites from reading to my own children, the *Larry Gets Lost* series. Are you familiar with any of these stories? Did my simple listing of the titles prompt you to remember or feel something?

Let's take that idea a step further and examine the utility of story through a quick thought exercise. Bring one of your own favorite childhood books to mind. What is the title? Recall the primary storyline. Who was the main character? What dilemma did they face? How did the story end? Close your eyes. Can you picture some part of it—perhaps the cover or a scene from the book—in your head? How does doing this make you feel?

Reflect for a moment. When was the last time you gave any thought to this particular story? Yesterday? Last year? A decade ago? Longer? Isn't it amazing that, no matter how much time has passed, you are able to recall it now?

This is partly due to the shape. Because there is one event that leads to the next and intensity often increases and then decreases, an effective story told well provides specific anchors. These are things that happen in the context of the narrative that can be recalled. This, in turn, makes it easier to remember and retell.

A good story also appeals to us—the audience—on an emotional level: both as the events of the story unfold and often afterwards as well. We may have laughed or cried. Perhaps we were entertained or learned an important lesson. In some cases, we might reflect on how we would act ourselves in a similar setting or express empathy for the characters and what they go through, feeling sad on account of their sorrows or sharing in the joy of their happy ending.

That is the kind of story I want you to have on your mind throughout this chapter as we study story from different angles and how we can use components of storytelling to inform how we communicate. No, we won't always be able to make people laugh or cry. But if we can use story to gain attention and get people to engage in productive ways, that's pretty powerful, too.

The structure of story

One key part of the storytelling process is *you*—the storyteller. I mean this both from the standpoint of the story you conceive when you plan and build your materials (our focus currently and in the following section) and how you ultimately tell that story (which we'll delve into in the final section of the book). As is the case when learning almost anything new, start simple. With time and practice, your comfort, experience, and skills for using story to communicate will build. As they do, you can refine your approach, becoming increasingly nuanced while better meeting the needs of your various communication situations.

I've observed this progression directly. The way I think about and teach story has changed over time, following my own learning and development in this space. Given that, I thought it would be helpful to walk you through a couple of specific characterizations of story that I have found useful. This brief exploration will give us a common language and structures to model as we think about applying story to our business communications.

A basic story: plot, twist, and ending

You may recognize the pieces of this basic story structure; they are the same ones I asked you to consider when we discussed the 3-minute story in Chapter 2. Here, rather than arrange the components linearly, I'll make a shape with a rise and fall—a small story mountain, as depicted in Figure 4.2.

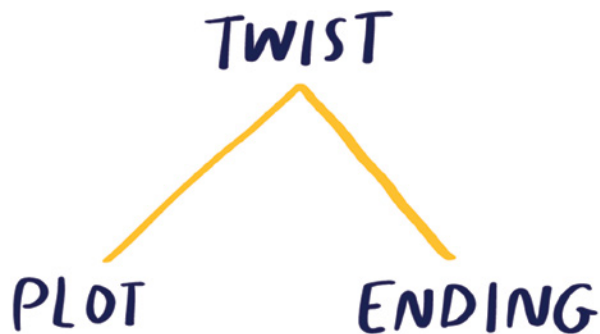


FIGURE 4.2 A basic story structure

The plot is context. This encapsulates what is happening at the onset of the story, where setting and characters are introduced. Things get carried, onward and upward, to the twist. This is the tension that lends shape to the story, something gone wrong that needs to be addressed. The ending solves that thing-gone-wrong and brings the story to its close, wrapping everything up neatly.

The simplest story: beginning-middle-end

When my oldest son was first learning about story at school, his first-grade teacher described it as being made up of a beginning, middle, and end. This is elementary (literally, for elementary school students) but a decent place to start. Aristotle is believed to have introduced this basic idea, proposing a three-act structure for plays. Following this model, Act One (the beginning) is the set-up. It lays out the plot and the characters. Act Two, the middle and typically longest segment, builds upon this, introducing complications, twists, and turns as the action escalates. Act Three (the end) is the resolution that brings the play to its close.

Note that this general structure is similar to the linear path introduced earlier in this chapter. Things move naturally forward in a logical manner. This is one progression we can follow for our business communications. As discussed, however, there is often an opportunity—and some serious accompanying benefits—to push beyond this, explicitly highlighting tension and bringing shape to our story.

The basic story structure of plot-twist-ending was what I focused on in my first book, *storytelling with data: a data visualization guide for business professionals* (Wiley, 2015), and it is the approach we commonly employ when we teach effective communication in a shorter workshop setting. The simplicity is useful, and many business scenarios can be mapped directly to it. It's a great way to get people to *start* thinking about story. If you hesitate at the idea of using story to communicate at your organization, this is a terrific first step. We'll come back to this idea and lay out specific tactics when we revisit tension later in this chapter.

Before we do that, let's examine another well-known story structure that builds on this basic version.

The narrative arc

One common way of depicting the path that a story takes is the narrative arc. Similar to the basic story structure, the beginning of the story is the plot: where we are at the start. Tension is introduced through an inciting incident. This tension escalates in the form of rising action that reaches its maximum peak at the climax, where there is a significant turning point in the story. Things relax over the falling action, a buffer that leads us to the resolution at the story's end. This is the general structure that the children's books I listed earlier each follow. Bring to mind the familiar story you conjured. I bet its primary storyline can be plotted along this path as well (shown in Figure 4.3).

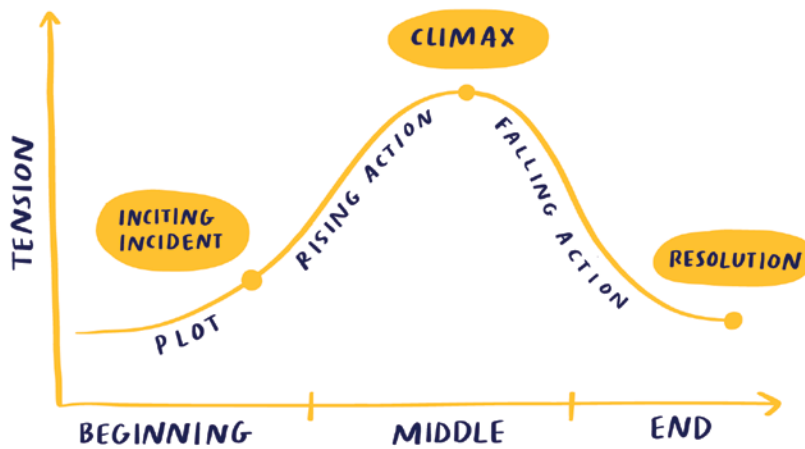


FIGURE 4.3 The narrative arc

When I first encountered the narrative arc, I experienced one of those eureka moments: *I've found it—the simple and relatable construct that's going to help me explain and teach story!* It's more complex than the basic plot-twist-ending but still simple enough to explain in mere minutes. Both familiar stories and real-life business scenarios can be mapped against it for illustration purposes. It can also be used as a schematic to plan future presentations. I will walk you through how to use it as a guide for your business story soon. Before that, let's look at some of its advantages.

There are a couple of important distinctions I want to highlight between the narrative arc and the linear path we touched on earlier. Perhaps the easiest difference to see is the shape. The linear path is a simple progression from left to right compared to the rise and fall of the arc. Tension is the magical component that lends form to the latter. That's perhaps the biggest single benefit of shifting how we generally address presentation organization from a linear path to the narrative arc—it forces us to identify the tension present in the situation. This is not the tension that matters to us, as the creators of the content, but the tension that matters to our audience. Whereas it's easy to organize our communication in a linear fashion without giving thought to others, it is almost impossible to neglect them when modeling after the narrative arc. To do the

latter, we are forced to think about our audience and the tension relevant to them. We'll talk further about this when we discuss tension in the context of planning your own presentation.

Something perhaps less obvious is that it's easy to treat the various topics or sections of content in the linear path as discrete and disconnected. The shift from one piece to the following can be abrupt. The narrative arc, on the other hand, forces connectedness. There is something about the shape that causes us to think about how we transition from one topic to the next in a way that the linear path doesn't invite. When we organize ideas using the arc as our guide, each component brings the story naturally forward. Things flow better when we plan content this way.

Freitag's Pyramid

An older dramatic structure is likely the predecessor to the modern-day narrative arc. Nineteenth-century German novelist and playwright Gustav Freitag expanded on Aristotle's three acts, outlining a five-part model for successful storytelling. Commonly known as Freitag's Pyramid, it has similar components to the narrative arc but is usually illustrated in a more angular form (depicted in Figure 4.4).

While the pyramid has basically the same pieces as the arc, different words are typically used to describe them. *Exposition* feels more robust than plot. The middle three sections are commonly expressed using similar language to what we saw with the narrative arc. I am partial to the French *denouement* (believed to be introduced post-Freitag), which suggests an unraveling of complexities (literally, "untying the knot").

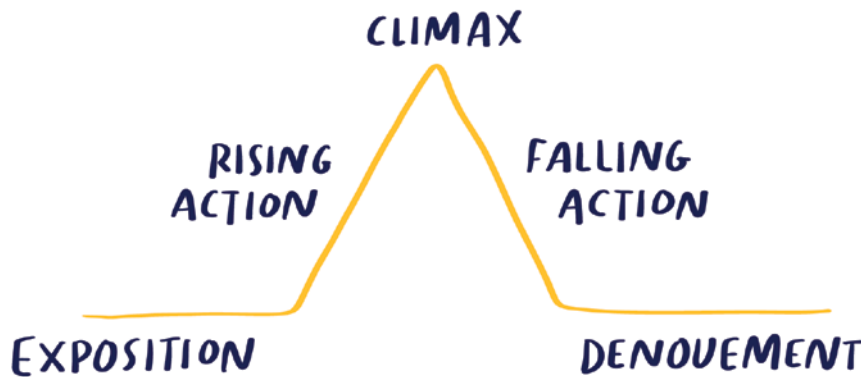


FIGURE 4.4 Freytag's Pyramid

Whether the simple plot-twist-ending or more elaborate narrative arc, these constructs are each simplifications of the full story. In the same way that the storyboard we created in Chapter 3 was a subset of the vast array of potential content that we brainstormed, our communication mapped against these structures will also be a curated path. They won't include every single detail. That version would look more like a jagged mountain.

Reality is a jagged mountain

Rather than a single smooth ascent and descent, the way things play out in reality is often more complicated. This is also true in the longer narratives of books and movies. There are ups and downs throughout that move the story forward, carrying us, entertained and engaged, from plot to ending. While the twist or climax might reflect the primary conflict or maximum point of tension, there are typically numerous other issues introduced and resolved over the course of the broader narrative. It is precisely because of all of these ups and downs that the story holds our attention, keeps us guessing, and provides points of satisfaction along the way.

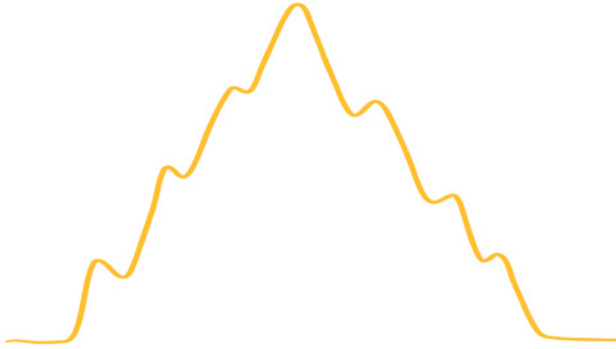


FIGURE 4.5 The jagged mountain

This jagged mountain could encapsulate every up and down over the course of a narrative—or, bringing this back to business, every oscillation through the duration of our project. While all of these ups and downs may be critical to keeping our attention over a 400-page book or two-hour movie, it's rare that you have this much time with or attention span from your audience in a work setting. Additionally, we don't necessarily need to convey the comprehensive story.

Different audiences will care about disparate levels of detail. The exec might only want the basic story or high-level arc. The finance partner will be interested in a completely distinct set of peaks, merging into a widely varying storyline or narrative, than what you would use to communicate to the marketing lead. A mixed group of stakeholders or conference attendees will require a separate combination of detail to suit their individual and shared goals. When we are the ones communicating, we generally must have a good sense of all or most of the peaks; from them, we should be able to identify and weave together the specific subset that will work for others. To say this another way: *you are not telling your story—you are forming a story for your audience.*

This seems like a good point to transition to the practical. We can use strategies extracted from story and the structures we've explored to communicate our work. Let's discuss that next.

Bringing story into business

Memorability, emotional appeal, and the ease with which we retell them are characteristics of story that we can tap into when communicating in a business setting. I have encountered many diverse circumstances for communicating, and I am hard-pressed to recall those that didn't benefit in some way from thinking about story. To fully consider story means reflecting on your audience and how they fit into that story so that it best resonates with them.

When you're initially beginning to incorporate components of story—particularly if this feels uncomfortable or countercultural at your organization—look for places where it is likely to work. Start there. There is too much risk to begin from a place of resistance. If it doesn't work, it could deflate your confidence, hurt your credibility, or discredit the method. None of these are good outcomes. They don't mean the approach can't be effective; they indicate that it didn't work in that situation, either due to the specifics of the scenario or the way it was executed.

When story can work...and when it may not

I'd characterize the ideal scenario for using story to communicate as follows. You want to lead people on a journey. You've done something—finished a project, become an expert on a topic, had a unique experience, conducted research, or completed an analysis—and are ready to take others through it to help them understand something in a new way, have a conversation, make a decision, or be inspired to make a change. Story is the path along which you can guide your audience to help make the action you seek transpire.

One instance where you might question the use of story is when it simply feels like too big of a leap from the way communication typically happens in your team or at your organization. If the status quo is to always present information in a certain manner, others may reject this departure from the norm. I once worked with an organization that had a required template for communicating project results. There were set components meant to be addressed in a

specified order (roughly mirroring the scientific process: observation, research topic, hypothesis, experiment, analysis, and conclusion). The consensus of the group I was working with was that any change to this would be unacceptable to their stakeholders. That may indeed have been the case; those inside an organization will typically have the contextual knowledge to take into account and use to guide their decisions.

That said, if you aren't getting the attention or driving the action you seek in a situation like this, perhaps addressing things differently is exactly what is warranted. One way to form a bridge between what people expect and a new approach is to do both. Complete what is mandatory (for example, create the normal communication that follows the set template). Pair this with the new format and let others know that's what you are doing. You could say something like, "Today, I want to try something a little different. I've still provided the expected documentation, and I'm happy to walk you through it. But first, I want to spend a few minutes telling you the story of our project." Obviously, it takes careful consideration to determine when something like this will work and when it runs the risk of backfiring. Spend your time crafting stories for the situations where it will help, not hinder, you.

As you begin using components of story to communicate, another place to tread lightly is in high-stake scenarios. Let's say you have an upcoming presentation to make to your company's senior leadership. Please don't do what I've just suggested—this is not the best setting to start incorporating story. Instead, test it out first in lower risk spaces, where you have others' support or where you are otherwise more likely to be successful. This will boost your confidence and credibility. Over time and with success, positive momentum builds and you can harness it, becoming increasingly proficient in how you use story in higher risk settings.

When you've identified a suitable situation to use story to communicate, start by identifying the tension.

Identify the tension

Tension is a critical—and oft overlooked—component when we share information in a business setting. When I teach the lesson on story in our workshops, I tend to get quite dramatic in my delivery, particularly in the discussion about tension. This is to emphasize the point but shouldn't be taken as a call to create drama for our stories to be effective. It's not about making up tension. If there weren't tension present, we'd have nothing to communicate about in the first place. Rather, it's about figuring out what tension exists in a given situation and how we can illuminate it for others. When we do this well, we get their attention and are in a better position to motivate them to act.

Think back to some of the lessons covered in Chapter 1. I cannot emphasize enough the importance of getting to know our audience and what matters to them. It's easy to concentrate on what is meaningful to us, but that's not a good way to influence. We need to step outside of ourselves and think about what tension exists *for our audience*. This relates back to one of the Big Idea components that we discussed in Chapter 2: what is at stake? When we've effectively identified the climax of the scenario and related it to the stakes for our audience, then the action we want them to take resolves the tension we've brought to light in our story.

Identifying the tension is a useful undertaking even if you don't go full-blown story and use the narrative arc to structure your communication. In the planning process, step back and ask yourself: what is the tension in this instance? What is the thing-gone-wrong or the thing-that-could-go-wrong that others will care about?

What's the tension in this situation?

As we've discussed, tension is a key component of story. But what should you do if the tension isn't obvious? First, identify what is at stake for your audience. I outlined a strategy in Chapter 2 for playing things out to extremes. Revisit that to see if it helps clarify. Focusing on the gap between the current and desired state is another tactic to help define the tension. Also try jumping ahead to the action—what do you want people to do? The steps you wish them to take will resolve or ease an issue. Starting with the action can help you back into the identification of tension. If you're still having trouble articulating the tension, talk through the scenario with someone else—a colleague, manager, or stakeholder. The conversation may enlighten you. Don't give up if the tension isn't immediately obvious; keep working to identify it. This will become easier with practice.

Once you've identified the tension, it's time to return to your storyboard and arrange it along the narrative arc.

Arrange along the narrative arc

When you need to get and maintain the attention of others, a well-structured story can help you do it. As we've discussed, arranging your communication using the narrative arc as a model assists with memorability and gives your audience something to retell to others, helping them spread your message.

One noteworthy aspect of the narrative arc is its shape. However, the smooth, steep, and symmetrical rise and fall depicted won't necessarily be the exact structure of your business story. Allow yourself leeway (we see stories in everyday life veer from this path, too, through flashbacks, foreshadowing, and so on). Your story might be flatter; the climax may merely be a small bump.

The highest point of tension might not come in the middle of your presentation. You could lead with it or build up to it over a longer period of time. Your general plan should incorporate the pieces of the arc (especially tension, as I've detailed). More important than following the exact form when we think about applying story to business communications is that it has a shape, one you've planned taking into account the context of how, what, and to whom you'll be communicating.

At this point, I typically clear off working space on my desk (or if I'm traveling, I'll do this on or transfer it to a large piece of paper for portability). I secure a stack of stickies and write one for each primary component of the narrative arc: plot, rising action, climax, falling action, and resolution. I arrange these sticky notes in the shape of an arc, with some space around each so I have room to add multiple stickies if necessary.



FIGURE 4.6 My sticky note narrative arc

This is one of the reasons I love the stick of sticky notes: I can easily relocate them from their storyboard and arrange them along the narrative arc. This step helps me confirm that each element of story is present. Let's review

the components of the arc, with some related thoughts and questions to use when rearranging your storyboard in this manner. The following is excerpted from my second book, *storytelling with data: let's practice!* (Wiley, 2019).

- **Plot:** What do others require in order to be in the right frame of mind for what you'll be asking of them? Identify the tacit knowledge you have about the situation that would be helpful to communicate directly to ensure people are working from the same set of assumptions or understanding.
- **Rising action:** What tension exists for your audience? How can you bring that to light and build it to an appropriate level given the circumstances for them?
- **Climax:** What is the maximum point of tension? Remember, the tension isn't for you—the tension is for your audience. Think back to the Big Idea and conveying what's at stake. What does your audience care about? How might you use that to get and maintain their attention?
- **Falling action:** This is perhaps the fuzziest of the components when it comes to application in a business setting. The main purpose is so that we don't go abruptly from the highest point of tension—the climax—to the ending. The falling action is a buffer to ease this transition. In our business stories, it may take the form of additional detail or further breakdown (e.g. here's how the tension plays out by business unit or region) or potential options you've weighed, solutions to employ, or discussion you'd like to facilitate.
- **Ending:** This is the resolution, the call to action. The ending is what your audience can do to resolve the tension that you've illuminated. Note that it isn't typically as simple as, "We found X; therefore, you should do Y." Our stories are often more nuanced than that. This ending could be a conversation you seek to drive, options to choose from, or perhaps even input you desire from others to fully flesh out your story. In any case, identify the action you want your audience to take and how to make it clear and compelling.

As I arrange my ideas along the arc, I frequently find myself reaching into my brainstorming pile from my storyboarding process and adding back (or forming new) ideas that will help me transition smoothly from one part of the arc to the next.

Sometimes, remapping my ideas in this manner means only slight changes to how I envisioned things in my storyboard. On other occasions, it's an entirely different path. In every case, I find that looking at what I'm planning through the lens of the narrative arc causes me to make some improvement over what I had previously. My hope in sharing my process is that it will help you to refine what you've planned for your presentations as well.

Once I've arranged my ideas along the arc, confirmed that each of the components are present, and perhaps made additional edits by adding or removing stickies, I step back and think about how it will work.

Using stories within a presentation

While I've outlined how to use the shape and components of story to structure your business presentations, there are also opportunities to use stories *within* a presentation.

I have incorporated personal and illustrative stories many times over the years, both on stage delivering keynote addresses and when teaching workshops. The specific stories I've told have run the gamut of topics: back-to-school shopping with my mom, a memorable childhood Christmas, my time working at Google, my son learning to read, and more. While the stories have been diverse, my motivation for telling them has been consistent. I use personal stories to share something about myself that others can relate to, engaging them on a deeper level. Each story is also meant to pique interest and illustrate or frame something important that I want people to remember.

Consider when you might tell a story to connect with others, illustrate a concept, make a point, build credibility, gain support, drive change, or inspire. To be successful integrating your own stories, look for ways to do so that will feel authentic to you. Map your intended story against the narrative arc. Determine which information to include or emphasize and which to leave out. Practice and get input from someone else. Use additional strategies outlined in Chapter 9 for refining through practice to ensure you tell your personal story masterfully.

As we've discussed, the narrative arc is a simplified schematic of the complete story. The full picture looks more like that jagged mountain we saw earlier. I'll use this opportunity to reinforce that you don't have to communicate *everything* to *everyone*. Get your specific audience and message in mind, and assess which points they have to know and what order will work best to convey your message and prompt the action you seek.

Once you're happy with the path you've outlined for your story, talk through it aloud. We'll discuss this strategy in the context of honing your delivery in Chapter 9, but for now think of it as a simple test to see whether the way you've arranged things creates a story that can be told. Make adjustments as necessary after completing this exercise.

After you have refined it on your own, discuss the story you've formed with someone else. As we saw with the Big Idea and storyboard, the process of explaining your strategy to another person is invaluable. Give an influential stakeholder visibility or seek input from a manager who can confirm whether you're on the right track. The conversation that ensues will almost always help you continue to polish your approach.

Now that we've explored how to apply story in general to structure our business communications, let's make use of it in a specific scenario.

Form a story: TRIX case study

We closed Chapter 3 with a storyboard showing one way to arrange the communication to my client team at Nosh. Let's take another look at that plan now and apply what we've learned in this chapter about story. Figure 4.7 shows the storyboard I created.

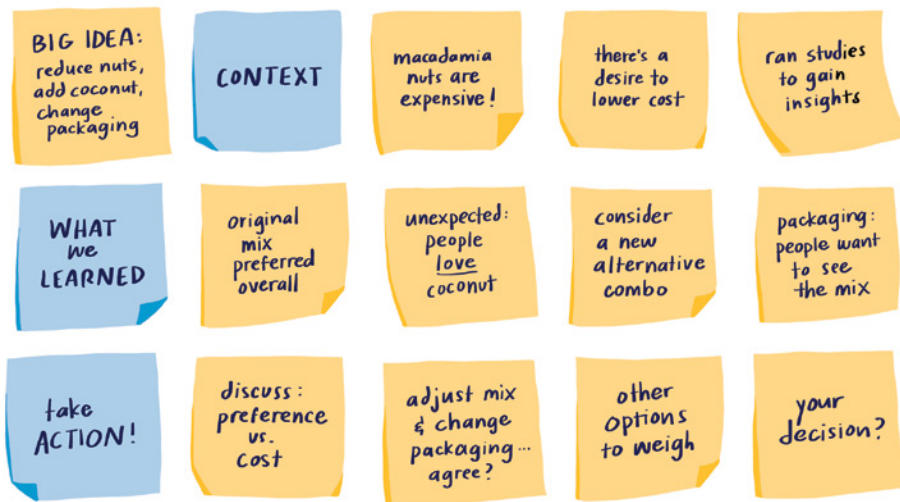


FIGURE 4.7 Storyboard for TRIX market research project

First, I clearly identify the tension. This scenario has tension at its core: the current mix of the popular TRIX trail mix isn't sustainable due to rising costs. That part of the tension is built into the context, the plot of my story, but it is distinct from the tension in the story I am communicating. What is the thing-gone-wrong that I can bring to light and use to prompt action among the client group at Nosh? The issue here is that there isn't a single clear fix—there were things we hoped would play out a certain way that didn't. The original mix was preferred overall. Yikes! That unwelcome news is going to get people's attention and appeal to something important to them.

I get a new stack of sticky notes and write the components of the narrative arc: plot, rising action, climax, falling action, and resolution. I remove individual stickies from my storyboard and arrange them along the arc that I've just created.

As I do so, I realize that I have cut out too much content in my simplified storyboard. In considering the arc, I'm reminded of my audience. It's our first time working with Nosh. I need to establish credibility in both our team and our methods. I must sufficiently impress them so that they want to continue to work with us.

In order to make that happen, this means some of the potential content I brainstormed and discarded originally may work its way back into my story. I have to find a good balance between the overarching story that will frame the discussion and ultimately drive my client team's decision with the detail that illustrates the robustness of our team's work. These goals feel at odds.

How should I move forward given this?

When I feel stuck—which I do here—there are a couple of strategies I typically try. First, I step back from the work and create some physical and temporal space to allow my perspective to develop. This could take the form of leaving my office and going for a walk or run. When I have the luxury of additional time, I turn my attention to other work, letting things ruminate in the back of my head until an idea sparks or I'm ready (or deadline constrained) to go back to it.

In this particular case, the sticky notes, in the form of a rough arc and also with a number of uncategorized ideas, sit on the unused side of my desk over the course of a few days. The entire time, ideas are brewing in my brain. I periodically visit the sticky notes: rearranging, adding, and taking away ideas. At one point, I am convinced that it should be a choose-your-own-adventure story, where I would begin by outlining the various streams of work that our team undertook and let the client team at Nosh dictate what direction to take. Upon further reflection, I realize this isn't a great idea. Given my familiarity with the project, our work, the data, and what we found, I am in a unique position to guide others through it. Putting them in control runs the risk of subverting my expertise and credibility. After discarding that idea, a useful one struck me. What if I *combine* my story arc with the linear path that outlines the full detail of all of the work the team undertook?

Another strategy I employ when I'm stuck or testing ideas is to discuss it with someone else. Doing this will often extricate me faster if I don't have additional time and have to push forward and meet deadlines. In this case, I vet my new idea with a colleague on the project team and then determine my plan. I'll start by telling the story of TRIX: what we learned through our in-depth research and analysis and the steps we believe should be taken. Then in the appendix, I will include the full detail of our work, organizing it in an easy-to-navigate fashion as evidence of the robustness of our undertaking. The latter is more than we might require for an ongoing client who already trusts our expertise and methodologies but makes sense given this specific scenario. This highlights what we should always aim to do—identify what success in the given situation looks like and plan an approach that is likely to bring it to fruition.

After deciding this, arranging the story along the arc becomes a quick exercise. I no longer felt the pressure to jam everything into the storyline, since we will also provide a comprehensive appendix. I identify the path I want to guide my audience on when I present our work and findings to them. See Figure 4.8.



FIGURE 4.8 Narrative arc for TRIX market research project

Similar to what I'd originally planned in my storyboard, I'll start with the ending—the decision I want to frame for the group. Then I'll set the plot: a key ingredient's increasing price means the trail mix recipe needs to be changed. In the rising action, I'll introduce the studies we ran and the options we explored, culminating in the climax that reveals some inconvenient truths: the original mix is preferred, and there were clear issues with both alternatives tested. In the falling action, I'll reveal that not all hope is lost; there were some interesting and unexpected findings from our studies. This will bring me to the end, the resolution, where my stakeholders will weigh our recommendation along with some other options for deciding how to move forward.

This isn't a huge change from my original storyboard. However, forming my approach using the construct of story helped me think about things in a different way. It brought my audience clearly into the picture. It helped me figure out the right balance of detail given our goals. As a result of all of this, I have a better plan now than the one with which I started.

I want you to feel empowered to do this as well. Critically think about your audience—who they are and how to identify and meet their needs. Craft your message. Compile the pieces you will communicate in support of that message. Form the story, the path along which you will take people to build understanding and inspire them to act. You've fully considered what success looks like and how you can align all of the components we've addressed so far to put yourself in a winning position.

You now have your plan of attack—the story you will tell.

It's time to create the materials that will help you do it.

